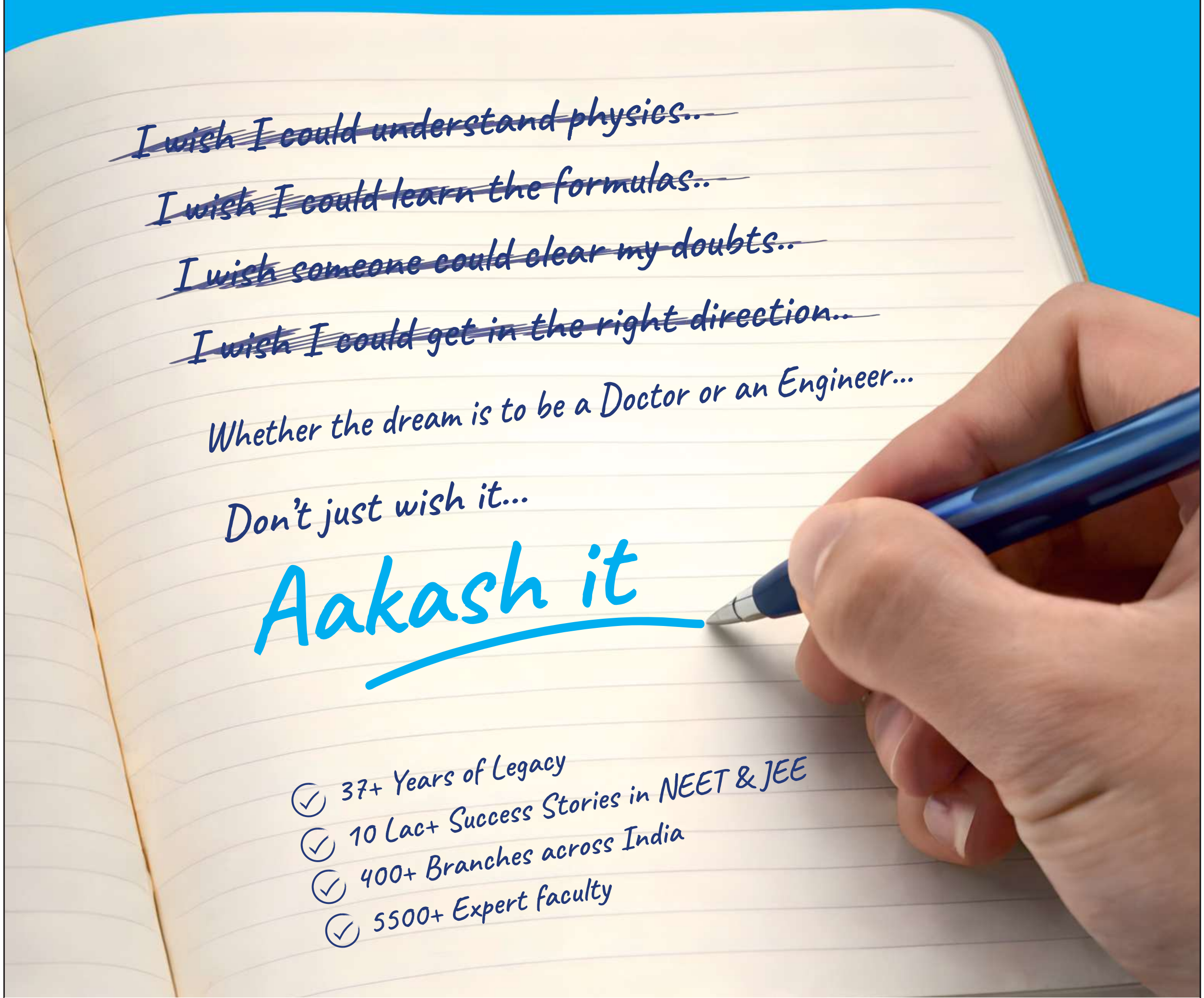




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Super Kings register second straight win
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Centre moots inter-State redistribution of Lok Sabha seats based on 2011 Census

Govt. circulates drafts of Constitution Amendment Bill and Delimitation Bill

If proposals are accepted, share of Lok Sabha seats of southern States will shrink

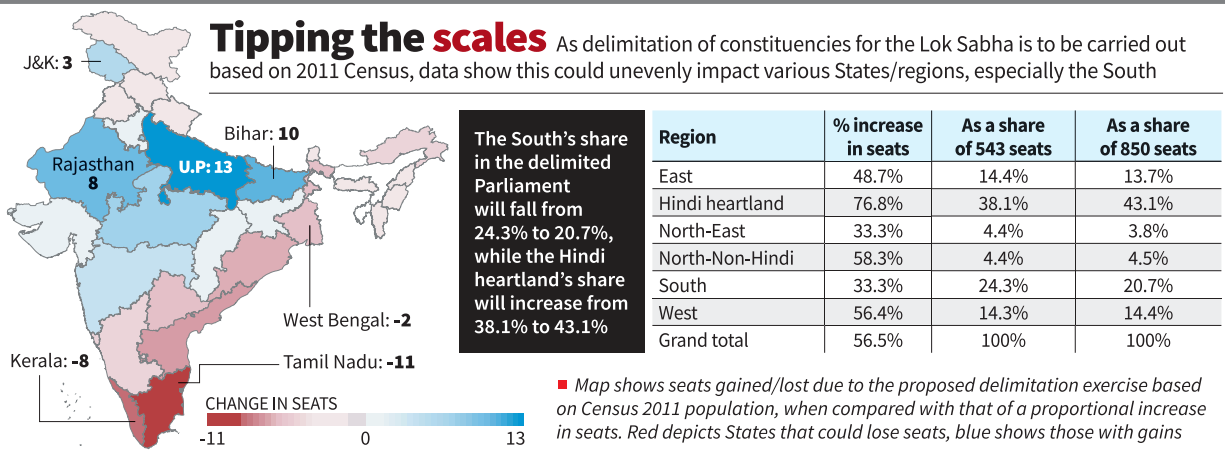
The Bills propose to raise strength of Lok Sabha to a maximum of 850 seats

Varghese K. George
Sobhana K. Nair
NEW DELHI

States that have stabilised their populations could see their share of representation in Parliament shrinking if proposals in the drafts of a Constitution Amendment Bill and a Delimitation Bill circulated by the Centre become law.

The Budget Session is reconvening on Thursday to consider the Constitution (131st) Amendment Bill and the Delimitation Bill, which the government says are aimed at expediting the implementation of 33% reservation for women in the Lok Sabha and the State Assemblies.

The Congress said the government was using women’s reservation as a facade to railroad inter-State redistribution of Lok Sabha seats without consultation, and ahead of the 2029 general election. “We will oppose this backdoor delimitation. We are 100% for women’s reservation and demand its immediate implementation within the existing strength of the Lok Sabha and Assemblies,” Congress MP Abhishek Manu Singhvi said. “In the



Stalin warns of massive protest

T.N. Chief Minister M.K. Stalin warned of a massive protest that would bring the State to a standstill if the Centre decided on delimitation affecting southern States and offering more political power to northern States.

» PAGE 6

Build consensus, Revanth tells PM

Telangana Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy wrote to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, calling for a national consensus on the proposed rise in seats and urging immediate implementation of women’s reservation without linking it to seat expansion.

Dangerous shift: Siddaramaiah

Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah opposed the proposal, saying, “If numerical strength begins to determine power, the need for broad-based support across the country will diminish. That is a dangerous shift.”

Attempt to divide India: Mamata

West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee on Tuesday said the BJP-led Union govt. has tabled the Delimitation Bill to divide West Bengal and India at large. They are doing it to gain political mileage, she said.

proposals there is not a whisper of the repeated assurance by the government that the inter-State seat distribution percentages will remain intact.”

The proposals emphatically seek to change the

seat distribution – indeed, that is stated in the objects and reasons of the Constitutional Amendment Bill itself. The statement notes that “while the freeze of seats on the basis of population figures of the 1971

Census served an important policy purpose, the country’s demographic profile has since undergone substantial changes, as reflected in the population figures of the latest published census, including

significant inter-State and intra-State population shifts.” The draft Delimitation Bill mandates that “it shall be the duty of the Commission to readjust, on the basis of the latest census figures, the alloca-

tion of seats in the House of the People to the States.”

If these proposals are enacted, the Hindi heartland States will see their share of Lok Sabha seats rise from 38.1% to 43.1%, while the southern States will see theirs shrink from 24.3% to 20.7%.

In combination, the Bills propose an inter-State redistribution of Lok Sabha seats based on the latest Census figures and an increase in the size of the Lok Sabha to a maximum of 850 seats – 815 for States and 35 for Union Territories – against the current ceiling of 550, while carving out 33% for women.

Under the existing constitutional scheme, Lok Sabha seats are distributed between States on the basis of the 1971 Census and within each State on the basis of the 2001 Census. Article 82 provides that this arrangement will continue “until the relevant figures for the first census taken after the year 2026 have been published”.

CONTINUED ON
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NEARBY



EPS slams DMK over Mullaperiyar dam issue

ANDIPATTI
AIADMK leader Edappadi K. Palaniswami asked farmers if they wanted to re-elect the DMK, which has not done anything to resolve the Mullaperiyar issue. » PAGE 6

Thirumavalavan releases VCK’s poll manifesto

CHENNAI
VCK founder Thol. Thirumavalavan on Tuesday released the party’s manifesto for the Assembly polls and said his party stood firmly by the two-language policy. » PAGE 6

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OPPORTUNITIES PAGE 3
► Over 80 Jobs in today’s issue

Nitish resigns; Samrat to become Bihar CM

Amarnath Tewary
PATNA

Bihar Deputy Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary is set to become the State’s first BJP Chief Minister after he was elected leader of the Bharatiya Janata Party and NDA legislature parties on Tuesday.

He met Governor Syed Ata Hasnain to stake his claim to form the new government in the State and is likely to take oath at the Raj Bhavan on Wednesday along with a few select

leaders, including two Deputy Chief Ministers from the Janata Dal (United).

Mr. Choudhary’s election followed days of suspense and speculation, and came an hour after Nitish Kumar officially resigned as Bihar’s longest serving Chief Minister.

Mr. Kumar, leader of the JD(U), became a Rajya Sabha member last week. In a post on X, he listed his government’s achievements.

‘DEVELOPMENT PLAN’
» PAGE 12

14 killed, 20 injured in power plant blast

Shubhomoy Sikdar
RAIPUR

At least 14 workers were killed and 20 injured after a boiler exploded at a power plant in Sakti district of Chhattisgarh on Tuesday.

Sakti Superintendent of Police Prafull Thakur said the explosion took place around 2 p.m. at the Vedanta Ltd. power plant in Singhitarai village.

“Fourteen workers have died and at least 20 sustained injuries. Police and district administration

teams are at the spot,” he said late in the evening. The injured were shifted to hospitals in Sakti and Raigarh.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Chhattisgarh Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai expressed grief over the incident. The Vedanta Limited Chhattisgarh Thermal Power Plant, in a statement, said the incident took place at the Unit 1 boiler plant.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10

Sri Lankan Navy arrests four T.N. fishermen

The Hindu Bureau
RAMESWARAM

The Sri Lankan Navy arrested four fishermen of Rameswaram and impounded their boat, between Dhanushkodi and Thalaimannar, on Monday night on the charge of crossing the International Maritime Boundary Line.

Sources said the fishermen – S. Sekar, 66; T. Sakthivel, 54; S. Arunagiri, 54; and V. Paulraj, 55 – ventured into the sea in the boat owned by S. Gladstone from the Rameswaram fishing jetty on Monday.

The Sri Lankan Navy



The Rameswaram fishermen who were arrested by the Sri Lankan Navy on Monday night. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

stopped them mid-sea and detained them.

The fishermen were taken to the Kilinochchi fishing camp.

Days after the families of 12 fishermen urged the Tamil Nadu government to intervene and secure the

release of the fishermen from the custody of the Sri Lankan Navy, the situation has become tense with the arrest of four more fishermen of Rameswaram and the seizure of their boat.

Families’ appeal

The families, along with the Tamil Nadu Fishermen Federation (Tamil Nadu Meenavar Peravai), appealed to the government to put an immediate end to the continuous arrest of fishermen.

Jesu Raja, a community leader, said the arrest of the four fishermen had put the spotlight on the government’s “indifferent”

attitude towards the fishermen’s plight.

‘No promise of solution’ “Had the Indian government given any serious thought to this long-standing issue, it would have found a solution years ago,” he said. “Yet, even during the election season, not a word has been spoken about finding a permanent end to the problem. If we were truly regarded as citizens, our voices would have been heard. But the situation reflects a deep indifference towards the coastal communities of Tamil Nadu and our right to live with dignity,” he said.

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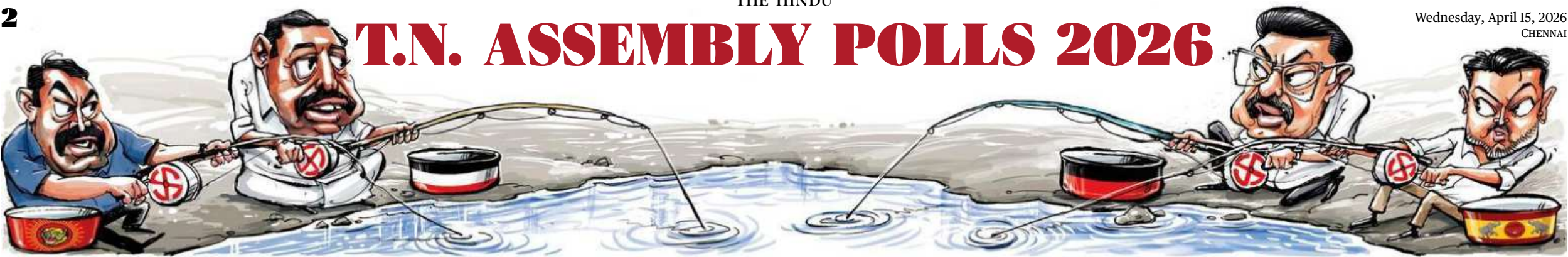
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Falling short: All parties have come up with various proposals in support of the farm sector, but they do not seem to enthuse farmers. E. LAKSHMI NARAYANAN

Despite parties’ poll promises, farmers fear for the future of agriculture

T. Ramakrishnan
CHENNAI

A joint family, owning about two dozen acres in a village near Sattur of Virudhunagar district, raised maize this year. The family spent around ₹9 lakh, but could earn only ₹4 lakh, suffering a loss of ₹5 lakh. “Our area is fit only for dry land farming, as there is no scope for irrigation through any river network. Of course, there is not much rain. This is why we have been raising crops such as maize, millet, or cotton, if possible. As an inter-crop, we sometimes opt for black gram,” explains an elderly member of the family.

Speaking of the economic viability of farming, the elderly person says that though the family has the means to withstand the loss this year, it has decided not to carry on farming by itself hereafter, as the elders are quite sure that the younger members of the family are not keen on pursuing farming.

In the village of Mullukurichi, located at the foot of the Kolli Hills, and about 30 km from Rasipuram in Namakkal district, P. Balachander, 57, has been undertaking farming on 11 acres, passed down to him by his father about 35 years ago. Despite much of his land having been covered under dry land farming, the availability of free power supply for agriculture enables him to raise a mix of crops, including paddy. In Namakkal district, he is one of those chosen under a scheme of the Union government for reducing the consumption of chemical fertilizer. The idea is to cut consumption by 50% and encourage agriculturists to shift to natural and organic practices.

He has been able to make a modest gain, but his son and daughter-in-law, both well-placed in the IT sector in Bengaluru, have conveyed their disinterest in agriculture to him. “After me, no one in my family is going to take up farming,” Mr. Balachander says, with a tinge of sadness.

These two examples are not confined to the southern or western districts of the State; similar stories can be heard in the fertile Cauvery delta region and northern districts such as Cuddalore and Villupuram. But a perusal of the manifestos of the principal Dravidian parties – the DMK and the AIADMK – reveals that they have not captured this issue. The same holds good for the NTK, which is contesting in all 234 constituencies on its own. Yet, all the parties have come up with various proposals in support of the farm sector, though they do not seem to enthuse the farmers, as the proposals are generally viewed as the extension of the existing schemes, and the ultimate test lies in their effective implementation.

Use of inputs

“Two issues need to be tackled on a war footing,” says Mr. Balachander. Many farmers still do not have adequate knowledge of the use of inputs, be it seeds or manure. They need to be sensitised to their judicious use. Soil test has to be performed at regular intervals, he adds. Another problem is the absence of a vibrant agricultural marketing mechanism, he notes. The Virudhunagar agriculturist calls for a reliable procurement system for maize, millets, and other crops. Hassles in securing loans from agricultural cooperative societies have to be eliminated, he says.

Silver lining

But there is some room for cheer. M.G. Rajendran, a farmer of Malaiveppankuttai village in Sendhamangalam taluk of Namakkal district, has two sons, both of whom have taken up farming despite having completed higher studies. “In my case, I am lucky, as my sons are deeply interested. They experiment with drip irrigation and organic farming. If the Union and State governments demonstrate that their policies and schemes yield moderate gains, it will build confidence among the youth to take up agriculture.”

Higher vote share for Vijay could work to the DMK’s advantage, says CPI leader

Within the TVK, there is an educated group of people keen on defeating the BJP front which, they believe, is acting against T.N.’s interests. Many of them recognise that voting for Vijay may not yield benefits. They understand that the DMK alliance has an edge over the AIADMK front, says Veerapandian

INTERVIEW

M. Veerapandian

B. Kolappan

CPI Tamil Nadu secretary M. Veerapandian feels the ruling DMK is heading towards a massive victory, surpassing even the predictions of Chief Minister M.K. Stalin. Dismissing the argument that the contest is close on the ground, he says the votes polled by actor C. Joseph Vijay’s TVK would only help the DMK-led alliance. “While he is drawing crowds, he lacks the organisational strength to convert them into votes,” he says in a telephone interview to *The Hindu*. Edited excerpts:

You have been touring the State, campaigning for the DMK-led alliance. How do you see the prospects of the front?

There is a wave in favour of the DMK-led front. I am confident we will surpass Chief Minister M.K. Stalin’s predictions and win more than 200 seats.

What gives you this confidence? There is an opinion that the contest is close on the ground.

Such claims are part of a deliberate propaganda. I have been visiting hundreds of villages and speaking at small meetings. The people feel the DMK-led alliance is strong. The welfare measures of the government have reached the people, and the alliance has become a major talking point. Voters, who are not affiliated to any party, are weighing various factors, and are inclined towards the DMK-led alliance, which they see as secular and committed to preserving the unity of Tamil Nadu. They believe the alliance will drive development.

In contrast, the BJP-AIADMK combine is promoting a kind of politics that could create social tension. The BJP has stalled welfare schemes and denied approval for Metro Rail projects in Madurai and Coimbatore. The people are also questioning its attempts to stall the [Kalaigñar] university in Kumbakonam.

Mr. Vijay’s TVK appears



to be getting a considerable vote share. Who stands to gain from his political entry?

There are two sections within the TVK. They cannot be dismissed as fans of Mr. Vijay. Among them is an educated group with a strong concern for the welfare of society, the State, and the nation. This section is keen on defeating the BJP-led alliance as it believes the front is working against Tamil Nadu’s interests. Many of them still see Mr. Vijay primarily as an actor, and recognise that voting for him may not yield tangible benefits. They also understand that the DMK-led alliance has an edge over the AIADMK-led front. If he secures more votes, it may ultimately benefit the DMK-led alliance, as he is unlikely to significantly erode the vote

share of the DMK and its allies.

But another view is that the election could result in a hung Assembly...

That may be one opinion. However, both Mr. Vijay and the AIADMK-led alliance are targeting the DMK, which indicates that the DMK remains strong on the ground. There is a visible surge of support for our alliance in villages. Meetings addressed by former Chief Minister Edappadi K. Palaniswami often draw smaller crowds. Ultimately, elections are won through door-to-door campaigning. Our alliance is leading on that front.

There is also a perception that not only young people but also all sections prefer Mr. Vijay, as they have

Intense contests brewing in Cauvery delta, the rice bowl of Tamil Nadu

S. Ganesan

The agrarian heartland spread largely over the Cauvery delta in the central region of Tamil Nadu has gained a reputation for tipping the scales in recent elections. The party with the most number of seats from this region went on to form the government in the past few elections. The region could play a crucial role in this election, too.

The DMK, which had won 37 of the 41 constituencies in nine districts in 2021, is keen on retaining its supremacy. The AIADMK, which had suffered heavy losses owing to a split in the votes caused by the AMMK and the NTK in several constituencies in 2021, is hoping that the anti-incumbency factor will turn the tide in its favour. Besides, with the AMMK and the TMC(M) on its side now, it hopes to bridge the gap in the core delta.

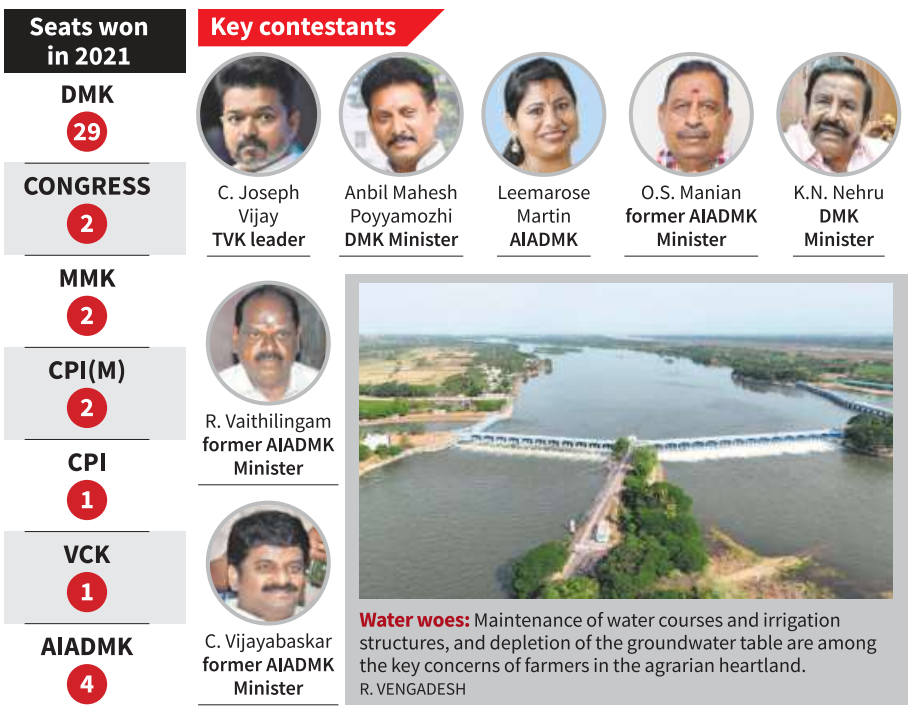
New entrant

The scenario has been spiced up with TVK founder and actor C. Joseph Vijay entering the fray in Tiruchi East (besides Perambur in Chennai). But the DMK is riding high on confidence, thanks to its welfare schemes and the strength of its mega Secular Progressive Alliance. With former AIADMK Minister R. Vaithilingam crossing over to the DMK, the party is expecting to overcome its weakness in Orathanadu, and has nominated him there. Orathanadu is one of the four constituencies, besides Virallimalai, Vedaranyam, and Nannilam, where the DMK lost in 2021.

Issues of farmers and fishermen dominate the narrative, as evident from the campaign of Chief Mi-

Poll position

The DMK-led alliance had recorded a stunning performance in the central region in 2021, winning 37 of the 41 seats, and is aiming to do better. The AIADMK-led alliance is trying to recover lost ground in the largely agrarian region, where farmers’ issues have triggered heated debates in recent days



KEY ISSUES

- Hiking the minimum support price for paddy and sugar cane
- Karnataka’s move to build a balancing reservoir across the Cauvery at Makedatu
- Slow progress of the Cauvery-Gundar intra-State river-linking project
- Maintenance of irrigation canals and structures in the Cauvery delta
- Frequent arrests of and attacks on Tamil Nadu fishermen

nister M.K. Stalin and AIADMK leader Edappadi K. Palaniswami. Karnataka’s move to build a reservoir across the Cauvery at Makedatu, and frequent arrests of fishermen by the Sri Lankan Navy on the charge of poaching have been simmering issues.

Farmers also have other concerns such as getting a fair price for their produce, maintenance of water courses and irrigation structures, and depletion of the groundwater table. The “failure” of the DMK government to pursue the intra-State Cauvery-Gundar link project has disap-

pointed farmers in the dry Pudukkottai district. Industrial growth, too, has been rather slow, though the Perambalur-Tiruchi-Pudukkottai belt has witnessed the emergence of a few new industrial units in recent years.

“But over the past five years, the DMK government has earned a reputation for being anti-people. All sections are disenfranchised. People have a soft corner for Mr. Palaniswami, and believe he will fulfil what he promises, unlike Mr. Stalin,” says former AIADMK Minister O.S. Manian, who is seeking re-

election from Vedaranyam. Veteran DMK leader and former Union Minister of State for Finance S.S. Palanimanickam maintains that the NDA stands “no chance” in the region.

The BJP will face a litmus test as it has been allotted five seats, including three in Pudukkottai, where it has little presence. An intense multi-cornered fight is brewing in several constituencies. Mr. Vijay’s popularity, along with the sizeable support for NTK leader Seeman, makes the contests all the more unpredictable.

AI memes on social media catch Gen Z’s eye this election

Sahana Mira S.
CHENNAI

One of your chief ministerial candidates is in a Superman avatar online, and if you keep digging into this, your social media algorithm decides to flood you with more such memes. But the catch is that these are easily identifiable as AI-generated, leaving little room for concern over deepfakes, at least for now.

Zoheb, a 25-year-old product marketer from Chennai, says there was a time when only a few media houses came up with animations of political candidates during the election season, but now, almost anyone can create them with the help of AI.

“It’s fun to look at, but it doesn’t cloud my judgment or influence my decisions. When I vote, I look at a few things, in terms of economy, infrastructure, jobs created, facilities for the people, companies that have invested here after seeing Tamil Nadu’s potential, and welfare schemes,” says Mr. Zoheb. That said, he admits, the memes are a quick way to remember, and remind the people of, what has happened – perhaps a recall mechanism.

Self-awareness

Cyndia B.K., a law student, says it takes a certain level of self-awareness to not rely on AI to make judgment calls and use it only as a tool to recall the goings-on. “I don’t think that can be said of a common man. A lot of people believe exactly what’s there on the internet. Information is quite accessible, and it is

completely decentralised to a point where you don’t know if it’s real or fake,” says Ms. Cyndia.

Earlier, the people spent time on understanding political manifestos, and expressed their political views by writing about them, she says. “Now, it has become far simpler, since memes are a means of expression for some in the Gen Z crowd. They can just put a cool picture of their favourite political candidate, and dress them up in superhero avatars or villainise them – however they feel about them,” she adds.

It is perhaps true that the “war on the walls” has been shifted to the palm of one’s hand, since all kinds of memes are crowding the social media feeds. “One category of memes is where the party leaders speak to the viewers, which is completely AI-generated, and some of them are indeed funny,” says Nivedha, a 25-year-old technical consultant from Chennai.

But chances are that some senior citizens, who are not tech-savvy, may get manipulated by such content, she says.

Ms. Nivedha says it could be a part of the parties’ new PR strategy of either praising their own leaders or bashing the others. “Eventually, AI memes could go beyond satire. When you present content, the audience that’s consuming it also plays a role in how it’s being perceived. When social media has lots of young users, memes could be perceived as realistic information,” Ms. Cyndia adds.

Plea in Madras HC seeks I-T probe into Udhayanidhi’s asset disclosure

The petition filed by a voter from the Chepauk-Thiruvallikeni Assembly constituency claims there are several discrepancies between the affidavits filed by Udhayanidhi for the 2021 and 2026 Assembly election; court to hear the petition today

Mohamed Imranullah S.
 CHENNAI

A writ petition has been filed in the Madras High Court seeking an inquiry by the Director-General of Income Tax (Investigation) and the Union Ministry of Corporate Affairs into the alleged material discrepancies in the assets declared by Tamil Nadu Deputy Chief Minister Udhayanidhi Stalin for the 2021 Assembly election and the election scheduled for April 23 this year.

The petition has been listed for hearing before the First Division Bench of Chief Justice Sushrut Arvind Dharmadhikari and Justice G. Arul Murugan on Wednesday. R. Kumaravel, 56, a resident of the Chepauk-Thiruvallikeni Assembly constituency, from where Mr. Udhayanidhi is contesting for the second consecutive time, has filed the writ petition.

‘Suppression of assets’
 Filing the case through his counsel V.R. Shanmuganathan, the petitioner said



The petitioner said Udhayanidhi Stalin had declared in 2021 that he had invested ₹7.36 crore in Red Giant Movies, but such an investment had not been mentioned in the 2026 affidavit.

a comparative analysis of the affidavits filed by Mr. Udhayanidhi in 2021 and 2026 reveal disappearance of previously declared assets, unexplained variation in loans, mis-characterisation of financial transactions, and contradictions between affidavit disclosures and corporate filings. The petitioner said Mr. Udhayanidhi had declared to have invested ₹7.36 crore in Red Giant Movies in 2021, but such investment was absent in his 2026 affidavit.

Instead, the latest affidavit claims that his spouse had invested ₹2.63 crore in the company involved in film production and distri-

bution. “This transition is neither explained nor supported by any disclosure of transfer, sale, divestment, or restructuring,” he complained.

The litigant went on to state, “Such disappearance of a high-value asset, coupled with its partial reappearance in a different name at a significantly reduced value, constitutes a classic case of suppression of assets and raises serious questions regarding beneficial ownership, routing of funds, and concealment of material particulars.”

Further, claiming that the 2021 affidavit of the DMK leader had disclosed that he had advanced a

loan of ₹11.06 crore to Snow Housing Private Limited, the petitioner said the 2026 affidavit reflected the loan amount to be only ₹10 crore without any explanation whatsoever as to whether the rest of ₹1.06 crore had been repaid, written-off, converted, or otherwise adjusted.

“The absence of any explanatory disclosure renders the statement incomplete and misleading,” he said, adding that the statutory financial statement filed by Snow Housing before the Ministry of Corporate Affairs for 2021-22 disclosed receipt of loan to the tune of ₹17.69 crore from Mr. Udhayanidhi, thereby creating a direct contradiction with respect to the actual loan amount.

The petitioner said the gravity of the situation gets compounded by the fact that Snow Housing had not filed its statutory financial statements for three consecutive years after 2021-22.

He also claimed that Mr. Udhayanidhi’s 2026 affidavit declares an amount of ₹5.76 crore having been in-

vested by his spouse in Raj Promoters Private Limited, whose financial statement for 2024-25 discloses a loan of ₹6.75 crore received from her. “A loan and an investment are fundamentally different in law and accounting and mischaracterising one as the other is a material misrepresentation. Such mischaracterisation is deliberate, as it alters the nature of financial exposure and conceals the true legal relationship between the parties,” the petitioner contended.

Mr. Kumaravel also said the Deputy Chief Minister had a relatively modest income aggregating to approximately ₹2.02 crore over a period of five years prior to 2020, whereas the subsequent years reflect a sharp increase in income, aggregating to over ₹10.98 crore.

“The absence of correlation between income and asset creation raises legitimate concerns regarding the source of funds and the possibility of undisclosed financial channels,” he said.

The Hindu Bureau
 CHENNAI

A youth from Chhattisgarh was arrested for snatching a mobile phone from a person waiting at a bus stop in

Sembium area.

According to the police, the accused, Ranbir alias Esu, snatched the mobile phone of Gajapathi, 46, and attempted to flee. Gajapathi raised an alarm

and, along with a few passersby, chased and caught the accused. They handed over 19-year-old Ranbir to the Sembium Police Station Crime Wing, who then arrested him.

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THE HINDU OPPORTUNITIES

Over 80 Jobs in today’s issue

GENERAL

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GENERAL

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CM YK

INBRIEF



Firefighters who lost their lives on duty honoured

Director General of Police, Fire and Rescue Services, Seema Agrawal led serving officers and personnel and retired officers in paying homage to firemen who had died in the line of duty, on the occasion of the Fire Service Day on Tuesday. At an event held at the headquarters of the Directorate of Fire and Rescue Services in Egmore, Ms. Agrawal read out the names of fire service personnel in the State, who lost their lives on duty from 1955.

House owner stabs tenant over rent dispute, arrested

Syed Ahmed, 62, was arrested for attacking his tenant in J.J. Nagar with a knife after the latter delayed the payment of ₹1,000. Police said Rambahadur, 42, a native of Nepal, was residing in a rented house in Padi. On April 11, Syed Ahmed, allegedly confronted him and attacked him with a knife. Rambahadur sustained bleeding injuries, and is undergoing treatment.

Text & Context and Science

Weekday features on *The Hindu* epaper (epaper.thehindu.com) carry explainers, special articles and quizzes. In the latest issue (April 15, Wednesday), the following articles are available:

- What are the legal consequences of piracy? newsth.live/moviepiracy
- New cell therapy shows promise to treat frailty among elderly newsth.live/frailty

You can use your smartphone's inbuilt features to access these articles. If it's an Android phone, use Google Lens to read and tap the url to access an article. If it's an iPhone, use Live Text on camera to do the same.

DMK candidate for Villivakkam outlines plans for infrastructure development

We will establish a world-class library and knowledge hub near the upcoming Villivakkam Metro station, says Karthik Mohan. Skill development centres for the youth will be established in every ward, along with entrepreneurship hubs that offer mentorship and digital literacy training, he adds

INTERVIEW
Karthik Mohan

Sangeetha Kandavel
CHENNAI

Villivakkam constituency is emerging as one of the most closely watched battlegrounds this election, and at the centre of it is Karthik Mohan – a 44-year-old first-timer – stepping into a high-stakes political arena. Fielded by the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), he faces opponents including Aadhav Arjuna, the second-in-command of the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK), S.R. Vijayakumar of the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) and S. Roshini of Naam Tamilar Katchi.

Here are the edited excerpts of the interview he gave to *The Hindu*:

You’ve long been known as ‘Anna Nagar Karthik’, but in your first political innings your party has decided to field you from Villivakkam – a different political terrain altogether.

The party decided that I was the best fit to fight this seat, and I accepted it happily. I have built a strong

reputation in Anna Nagar through the work I have done alongside my father over the past 10 years. This experience has given me a clear understanding of what an MLA’s responsibilities are. If I am elected as the MLA of Villivakkam, I will know what needs to be done from day one. As it is a neighbouring constituency to Anna Nagar, I am confident I can adapt quickly and carry out my work effectively.

Your opponents say your candidature reflects dynastic politics, given that you are the son of M. K. Mohan (Anna Nagar MLA). How do you respond to that?

First of all, legacy is not a wrong thing. Also, I believe I bring experience – I have seen my father serve over the years – and that has given me insights. I have also been the IT Wing Deputy Secretary for the party for the past seven to eight years and have worked on the ground with the cadre. This time, the Chief Minister has given opportunities to around 60 new candidates.

With Aadhav Arjun—the number two in Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam—entering the fray, Villivakkam is set for a high-stakes



contest. How do you assess this challenge?

I’m not here to talk about other people’s strengths and weaknesses. But since you’ve asked me this question, let me say this – we are here with a concrete plan.

Our Chief Minister has clearly stated what we are going to do. Others are talking about movie releases and who released what, but that is not what people want. They want to know what your party is going to do for the people of the State.

Villivakkam has been under the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam for the past five years, yet flooding continues to affect areas in the constituency including at SIDCO Nagar. What went wrong, and how will you ensure a lasting solution?

that can be fixed overnight. It is a densely populated and one of the oldest parts of the city, and it has developed this way over time. With regard to traffic, we are evaluating whether certain roads can be converted into one-way routes to ease congestion.

What about social infrastructure?

Villivakkam needs more development, particularly in terms of parks and open grounds. There is a significant amount of available land, and we plan to use it to create strong social infrastructure. Villivakkam has a large population of working professionals and retired residents, and there is a clear demand for more parks and recreational spaces. Our goal is to enhance the overall quality of life and improve the happiness index of the people here.

For the past five years, Villivakkam has been represented by A. Vetriazhagan of the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam. What concrete work has been delivered during this period?

A *Mudhalvar Padaippagam* was established in Ayanavaram to support community learning and development. A storm-water drain

was constructed from Kunjitham Street to Vellala Street. The Maternal Hospital at United India Nagar was reconstructed and upgraded to improve maternal healthcare services (ongoing work). Additionally, India’s first Ornamental Fish Trade Centre, with 188 outlets, was set up and inaugurated by M. K. Stalin.

If elected, what is your five-year vision to transform the constituency?

We will establish a world-class library and knowledge hub near the upcoming Villivakkam Metro station. To address last-mile connectivity, we plan to introduce a comprehensive mini-bus network, ensuring every residential colony is well connected to major arterial roads. We will transform areas like Baba Nagar and Jaganathan Nagar with international-standard parks. To bridge the employment gap, we will set up youth skill development centres in every ward, along with entrepreneurship hubs that offer mentorship and digital literacy training for local youth. The Tasmac outlet on North Red Hills Road will be relocated. We will develop Ayanavaram into a sporting hub by establishing a world-class sports facility centre.

2 held for abducting, attacking businessman over unpaid loan

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Maduravoyal Police arrested two men for abducting and attacking a 34-year-old businessman for failing to repay a loan.

Police sources said the complainant, Sureshkumar, 34, a resident of Valasaravakkam, runs a garment business. He had borrowed ₹2.10 lakh from Balaji in January this year

to expand his business and repaid ₹60,000 in two instalments. He agreed to repay the remaining ₹1.5 lakh by April 5.

On April 11, Balaji and his associate Narasimman went to Sureshkumar’s house, where an argument broke out. The police said the duo abused him, assaulted him with an iron rod, and abducted him in a car. They assaulted him in the vehicle and demanded

immediate repayment of the balance amount. Sureshkumar transferred ₹50,000 online, after borrowing the amount from a former employer. The accused later dropped him near Arcot Road after issuing threats. Based on his complaint, the Maduravoyal police registered a case and arrested Balaji, 32, of Nerkundram, and Narasimman, 31, of Alwarthirunagar.

Federation of Anna Nagar Residents’ Associations brings candidates together to discuss civic issues

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

With Anna Nagar constituency heading for a four-cornered contest in this Assembly election, the Federation of Anna Nagar Residents’ Associations (FOARA) brought candidates on an online platform on Tuesday to discuss their civic demands and poll promises.

The federation presented a charter of demands to address the increasing stress on infrastructure and mobility in Anna Nagar.

No-vending zones
The demands include enforcement of no-vending zones and prevention of encroachments as it affected pedestrian movement and residential streets.

Highlighting various other demands, the federation’s president R. Sukumar said residents want multi-level car parking facilities to be constructed in various parts of the constituency to address parking issues, and also ensure last-mile transport connectivity to ensure optimal use of Metro Rail services.

Besides flood mitigation interventions, ageing sewer

lines in the localities must also be upgraded. S. Gokula Indira from AIADMK, C. Shankar from NTK, and V.K. Ramkumar from TVK, who took part in the online interaction, outlined their poll promises. They also responded to residents’ questions, including whether they would consult residents before decisions on infrastructure development, and

how they would address constituency issues even if their respective parties did not form the government.

The candidates agreed to speed up works related to upgrade basic infrastructure facilities like storm-water drains and sewer network, encroachment removal, particularly in footpaths, and implement pending flood mitigation projects.

PIL in HC seeks headphone-based audio-enabled VVPAT system in polls

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

A public interest litigation petition has been filed in the Madras High Court seeking a direction to Election Commission of India (ECI) to introduce headphone-based-audio enabled Voter Verifiable Paper Audit Trail (VVPAT) system during the polling for Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly elections on April 23, 2026.

The petition filed by Chennai-based public charitable trust Nethrodaya, working primarily for the empowerment of the visually challenged, has been listed for hearing before the first Division Bench of Chief Justice Sushrut Arvind Dharmadhikari and Justice G. Arul Murugan on Wednesday (April 15, 2026).

In an affidavit filed through his counsel R.S. Raveendhren, Nethrodaya founder and managing trustee C. Govindakrishnan, 55, said, under the current VVPAT system, a printing machine gets attached to the ballot unit of every Electronic Voting Machine (EVM) in order to



Nethrodaya, a public charitable trust, working for empowerment of the visually challenged, filed the PIL in the Madras High Court.

The affidavit stated that the VVPAT system in vogue does not enable the visually challenged to independently verify votes cast by them

confirm the voter’s choice. Immediately after casting of every vote, the VVPAT enables visual verification by printing the voter’s choice on a slip of paper.

The paper slip with the candidate’s details gets displayed for seven seconds behind a glass window on the printer before dropping into a compartment below.

Stating that the VVPAT system in vogue does not enable the visually challenged to independently verify the votes cast by them and makes them dependant on a companion, Nethrodaya suggested introduction of headphone based audio enabled VVPAT system for the benefit of those who could not verify visually.

The petitioner trust said, the objectives of the Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016 was to ensure equal rights and opportunities to the disabled in all aspects of life and promote their full and effective participation in society by creating a barrier

free environment and providing accessibility.

Statutory obligation
It said, Section 11 of the 2016 legislation creates a statutory obligation on the ECI as well as the State Election Commissions to ensure that all polling stations were accessible to persons with disabilities and all materials related to the electoral process were easily understandable by and accessible to them.

Stating that as many as 9.55 lakh people had been issued with Unique Disability Identity Cards (UDID) in the State as on October 28, 2025, according to information received under the Right to Information Act, 2005, the petitioner trust said, a considerable number of them were visually challenged. Hence it was essential to ensure the inclusion of the visually challenged in electoral process by making them independently verify the casting of their vote through headphone based audio enabled VVPAT system, the trust said and highlighted that a representation in this regard was made to the ECI on March 20, 2026.

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH

I have fought the good fight, I have finished the race, I have kept the Faith. 2 Timothy 4:7

Chittaranjan Soundarapandian

Audit Director (Asia Pacific), World Vision International (Retd.)

S/o Late Premella and D.I.A. Soundarapandian

Went to be with The Lord in the early hours of 14.04.2026.

Funeral Service & Burial at CSI St. George's Cathedral, Chennai, at 4 pm on Thursday (16.04.2026)

Latha (Wife), Jeffrey, Jacinth, Jonathan (Children) & Family

Contact: 99860 37366 / 93810 79923

DEATH

OBITUARY

26.07.1954 14.04.2026

We regret to inform that

Mrs. RANI SHANMUGAM

passed away on 14-04-2026

The last rites will be held on **15-04-2026 by 12 noon** at No. 111, Vellalar Street, Near Best Hospital, Kodambakkam, Chennai.

— Deeply Mourned by —

Mr. A.V. Shanmugam - Husband

Mr. S. Arunprasad - Son

Mrs. Anusha Selvam - Daughter

& Staff of Shanmugam Engineering Constructions

DEATH

RESPECTFUL HOMAGE

S.SUBRAMANIAN

DOB: May 28, 1950 | DOD: April 14, 2026

Deeply mourned by

M.Rajeswari (Wife), Manu Sanju (Son), Mini Sindhu (Daughter) and Family

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

5th Death Anniversary

MEERA THYAGARAJAN

(Central Bank of India)

DOB: 01-02-1964 DOD: 15-04-2021

We miss You, Maa. (Thyagu, Priyanka, Ritshesh, Aarav Advait, Family Members & Friends)

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BIRTHDAY REMEMBRANCE

Shri Mr.G.KRISHNASWAMY

Administrative Officer (Retd.), Agriculture Department, Tamil Nadu

We Love You Always

Family Members

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

NINTH DEATH ANNIVERSARY

MVM. SOLAYAPPAN

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18:22

RISE

04:05

SET

16:25

THURSDAY, APR. 16

RISE

05:56

SET

18:22

RISE

04:45

SET

17:20

FRIDAY, APR. 17

RISE

05:56

SET

18:22

RISE

05:29

SET

18:18

Chennai Weather

max

min

Tiruvallur

38

24

Chennai Airport

37

27

Chennai City

34

27

Chennai Airport Today

37°C Morning will be comfortable. Day will be very warm and uneasy. Night also will be comfortable. Dry weather to occur.

Chennai Airport Tomorrow

37°C The weather will be dry. Day will be very warm. Night will be comfortable.

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THE HINDU

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Maduravoyal treated as second-rung constituency by both Dravidian parties, alleges TVK candidate

Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) candidate for Maduravoyal Assembly constituency Revanth Saran blames the DMK and the AIADMK for not giving enough attention to the constituency which has over 3.6 lakh voters; 'People are thirsty for a change. They are fed up with the two parties, which give promises only on paper and don't deliver,' he says

Saptarshi Bhattacharya
CHENNAI

Porur had a relatively quiet morning on Tuesday without the bustling traffic, a holiday owing to the Tamil New Year, until the red-and-yellow brigade arrived. Drums, loud music, and an entourage of young men, women, and children ostensibly disturbed the peace. But people did not mind. Doors and windows flung open, as curious faces peeked out, trying to discern the source of the commotion. “Vijay-anna-nukku vote podunga, anna,” (please vote for Vijay, anna), a young woman told an onlooker, handing over a party pamphlet, which he received with a smile. As the colourful and noisy entourage went around the lanes and alleys of Ward 154 in Maduravoyal

constituency, people along the route seemed quite eager to catch a glimpse of the candidate. Perched atop the open-hooded vehicle specially purposed for campaigning was Revanth Charan, the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) candidate for Maduravoyal Assembly constituency. “Even though Maduravoyal constituency has 3.64 lakh voters, the infrastructure here is bad,” Mr. Charan says, alleging that both the AIADMK and the DMK candidates, who have alternately won the last two Assembly elections, have treated Maduravoyal as a second-rung constituency. Maduravoyal was carved out of the Villivakkam constituency during the delimitation exercise in 2008 and faced its first Assembly election in 2011, when G. Beer Rao of the



Pitching for change: Campaigning at Shanthi Nagar in Ramapuram on Tuesday, Revanth Saran said that apart from bridges and parks, Maduravoyal has not seen much development. B. VELANKANNI RAJ

CPI, which was allied with the AIADMK, won. In 2016, P. Benjamin of the AIADMK beat K. Ganapathy of the DMK and went on to become the School

Education Minister. In 2021, Mr. Ganapathy returned the favour. During the current election, both candidates are in the fray representing

their respective parties. Winning won't be an easy task, but Mr. Charan said he was quite positive. “People are thirsty for a change. They are fed up

Revanth Saran claims that Maduravoyal residents pay high property and water tax despite the area having poor infrastructure

with the two parties, which give promises only on paper and don't deliver,” he says. “Property tax is a crucial factor bothering people here. The BSR (Basic Street Rate) in the constituency is much higher than that of T. Nagar, Kodambakkam and those surroundings,” Mr. Charan elaborates. The infrastructure and amenities in those areas were better than in Maduravoyal, yet residents of Maduravoyal had to pay more property tax. He intended to set the anomaly right, if elected. Similarly, several apart-

ments and gated communities in the constituency lacked piped water supply and sewer connections, but they still ended up paying high water tax. Sometimes, it was around 30 per cent of the property tax, he pointed out. In the past five years, the government spent about ₹2.27 lakh crore for the development of infrastructure in the State. Proportionally, Maduravoyal should have received ₹1,600 crore. “There are two bridges and three parks. Apart from that, there is no development in this area,” he observes. Poor garbage disposal practices, pending patta issuance, badly maintained roads, waterlogging during monsoon, absence of CCTV cameras, poor street lighting, and women's safety were some of the other issues he highlighted.



Brinda Karat speaking at Manali in support of CPI(M) candidate for Tiruvottiyur L. Sundararajan on Tuesday. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

EPS paving the way for BJP, RSS to enter T.N., says Brinda Karat

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

CPI(M) Polit Bureau member Brinda Karat on Tuesday charged that AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami was paving the way for Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the RSS to enter Tamil Nadu. “He is bringing in such a toxic force, which has discriminated against Tamil Nadu over the past five years. The rights of Tamil Nadu, particularly its financial rights, have been undermined, curtailed and denied. They have tried to blackmail Tamil Nadu and obstruct its progress. They have also attempted to impose the three-language formula,” she said. Ms. Karat, who campaigned for the party's Tiruvottiyur constituency candidate L. Sundararaj in Manali, said the AIADMK was raising the issue of law and order while aligning with the BJP and RSS, which, she alleged, had the worst record on law and order and the harassment

of women in States they govern. “Who can forget the killing of 13 workers of the Sterlite unit in Thoothukudi by the police under the AIADMK government? I witnessed the terror caused by the AIADMK police there,” she said. Ms. Karat said that when the anti-farmer Bills and anti-labour codes were introduced in Parliament, AIADMK members in the Rajya Sabha supported them. She added that, but for the support of the AIADMK and PMK MP Anbumani Ramadoss, the BJP government could not have passed the Citizenship Amendment Act in Parliament. “Now they have come here to ask for votes,” she said. She further said that despite attacks on its financial rights, the Tamil Nadu government and Chief Minister M.K. Stalin, had stood firm in defence of social justice and the Constitution. “That is why a wave is building up throughout Tamil Nadu. The slogan of this wave is the return of the DMK government.”

DMK govt. strove for welfare of women, says Kanimozhi

The Hindu Bureau
THOOTHUKUDI

Thoothukudi MP and DMK deputy general secretary Kanimozhi Karunanidhi on Tuesday emphasised that the outgoing government in Tamil Nadu is a ‘government for women.’ Addressing an election rally in Vilathikulam on Tuesday, in support of the DMK candidate G.V.Markandayan, she remarked that BJP is running a ‘WhatsApp university,’ to train people to spread lies, and both Edappadi K.Palaniswami and BJP are claiming there is no peace in Tamil Nadu and that women are unsafe. Refuting this she noted, “I proudly say that this government, which has ruled for the past five years, is a government for women.” **Crime against women** She questioned the BJP's criticism by pointing to crime statistics in BJP-ruled states, stating that 66,381 crimes have been registered against women in Uttar Pradesh in the year 2023, 22,952 in Bihar, 47,101 in Maharashtra, 45,450 in Rajasthan, 32,342 in Madhya Pradesh



Kanimozhi campaigning for DMK candidate Karunanidhi at Kovilpatti constituency in Thoothukudi on Tuesday. N. RAJESH

and it was 8,943 in Tamil Nadu. Stressing that even this number should not exist, she said the BJP must consider its credibility to come to Tamil Nadu and level accusations. Ms. Kanimozhi highlighted that in Tamil Nadu complaints are registered, charge sheets are filed, with 91% of the cases resulting in charge sheets. In contrast she alleged that in many BJP-ruled states, even 70% of the cases do not see charge sheet filing. She also referred to the Pollachi sexual assault case, accusing the previous AIADMK government for attempting to shield the accused, while stating that the current government stands with victims and en-

sures justice. She alleged that Mr. Palaniswami had repeatedly betrayed Tamil Nadu's interests, urging the voters to teach him a lesson in the election. Later addressing an election campaign in Thoothukudi supporting the DMK candidate P. Geetha Jeevan, Ms. Kanimozhi highlighted Chief Minister M.K. Stalin's statement on delimitation. She said Mr. Palaniswami is not caring about the issue, instead claiming that DMK opposes the introduction of bill for women, she alleged. She stressed, “As long as the DMK and our alliance partners, who share our principles, stand together, no one will be able to take away the rights of Tamil Nadu.”

Man held for land registration fraud

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Central Crime Branch of the Avadi City Police arrested a 48-year-old man who was allegedly involved in land fraud using forged

documents. Kanchana, 59, complained that after the death of her husband and his brother, unknown persons duplied their Aadhaar cards, and forged documents to register their jointly-owned property

measuring one acre and 75.37 cents at Vilangadu-pakkam. Based on her complaint, the police arrested the accused, Gopal, 48, of Ayalacheri in Tiruvallur. He was remanded in judicial custody.

बिहार सरकार

न्यायालय, अनुमंडल दंडाधिकारी—सह—अनुमंडल पदाधिकारी, जयनगर (मधुबनी) (विधि शाखा)

:- अल्पकालीन आम सूचना :-

एदत द्वारा निम्नलिखित वाहनों के मालिक को सूचित किया जाता है कि बिहार मद्यनिषेध एवं उत्पाद अधिनियम 2016 के अन्तर्गत पुलिस/उत्पाद विभाग द्वारा अवैध शराब के परिवहन के आरोप में जप्त वाहनों के अधिहरण (Confiscation) हेतु प्राप्त प्रस्ताव के आलोक में बिहार मद्यनिषेध और उत्पाद (संशोधन) नियमावली, 2022 के नियम 12क के तहत संबंधित व्यक्तियों को वाहन शांति के आधार पर मुक्त करने हेतु अधिनियम, 2016 की धारा 58(3) के तहत यह आम सूचना बिहार एवं तमिलनाडु राज्यों में प्रकाशित कर सूचित किया जाता है कि यदि इस जप्त वाहन में किसी व्यक्ति/संस्था का हित निहित हो तो आम सूचना प्रकाशन की तिथि से 15 दिवस के अन्दर किसी भी कार्य दिवस को 11:00 बजे पूर्वोक्त न्यायालय, अनुमंडल दंडाधिकारी—सह—अनुमंडल पदाधिकारी, जयनगर के न्यायालय में वाहन के वैध कागजात सहित आप स्वयं या अपने अधिकांश के माध्यम से अपना पक्ष रखने/विहित प्रपत्र—IV में शांति का मुतासिल कर वाहन विमुक्ति हेतु आवेदन प्रस्तुत करें अन्यथा इन वाहनों को अधिहरित कर नीलामी हेतु आदेश पारित कर दिया जाएगा।

जप्त वाहन का विवरण निम्न प्रकार है :-

क्र०	वाद संख्या	वादी/प्रतिवादी/वाहन स्वामी	थाना का नाम	थाना कांड सं०	वाहन का प्रकार	वाहन संख्या	चेसिस नं०	ईजन नं०	अधिसूचित
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	11
1	35/26	सरकार	सरदार सारिक	जयनगर	186/25	मोटर साइकिल	TN09BP8078	MAT614012CRD01386	22LDICOR09DXYJO 9623

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अनुमंडल दण्डाधिकारी, जयनगर।

PR. No. 000952 (District) 2026-27

नशे की मार, बर्बाद करे सुखी परिवार।

NORTH WESTERN RAILWAY

OPEN E-TENDER NOTICE

For and on behalf of the President of India, Dy. Chief Engineer (Construction-V), North Western Railway, Jaipur invites online open E-Tendering System (Two Packet System) for the following work on prescribed electronic forms: (1) E-Tender No.: NWR/S-C/S/W M-J-P/CIVIL/1/514110102R (2) Name of work: Balance leftover work of Earth work in bank/cutting including Blanketing, Construction of Minor Bridges, RUB/LHS, FOB, Trolley refuges, Toe wall, Retaining wall, Pitching, Station buildings and Other structures, Platform, Platform shelters, Staff Quarters and Other ancillary works from Chakus (Including) to Jaipur (Including) between km 87.60 to km 131.27 in connection with Doubling of Sawai Madhopur-Jaipur section of North Western Railway. (3) Approximate cost of the work: ₹189,25,55,631.99/- (4) Earnest Money to be deposited: ₹3,78,51,100/- (5) Last Date & time for submission of E-Tender: 06/05/2026, 15:00 Hrs. (6) Website particular where complete detail of tender can be seen: IREPS website: www.ireps.gov.in (7) Officer email address: dycecljip@gmail.com 543-DK/26

Follow us on: NWRRailways

SOUTHERN RAILWAY

1) Name of works: Redevelopment of Arakkonam Railway Station under ABSS Phase-1 (Additional Items) - Electrical arrangements thereof.

2) E-Tender notice number: MAS/EGS/ET/02/2026-2027 dated 13-04-2026

3) Tender number: ME-29-II-1086R-2026

4) Value of work: Rs. 1,98,93,604/-

Further details regarding the tender may please be viewed from www.ireps.gov.in

Sr.DEE/G/MAS

MSME TECHNOLOGY CENTRE

MINISTRY OF MICRO, SMALL & MEDIUM ENTERPRISES, GOV. OF INDIA

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Time: 5:30 PM to 8:30 PM

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NORTH WESTERN RAILWAY

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पत्र सं. NWRGSGU(GEN)/07/2023-OI/CPMI/GSU/JUINWR दिनांक: 09.04.2026

मंडल रेल प्रबंधक, गति शक्ति, उत्तर पश्चिम रेलवे, जोधपुर द्वारा भारत के राष्ट्रपति के लिये एवं उनकी ओर से ई-निविदा के माध्यम से प्रचलित नियमों के अन्तर्गत निर्धारित प्रपत्रों में निविदा निम्न कार्यों के लिए क्रमानुसार आमंत्रित की जाती है:- ई-निविदा सूचना सं. 2026-27 : 01 कार्य का नाम व स्थान : Provision of additional platform shelters at Pipar Road Jn., Pipar City, Silar, Bhawli, Bilara, Kharia Khangar, Gotan, Merta Road stations in JU-MTD section & Ren, Jalsu Nanak Halt, Degana, Gachhipura, Borawar, Makrana, Bidiyat, Kuchaman City, Thathana Mithri, Naya Khardia, Nawa City, Gudha stations in MTD-FL Section of Jodhpur Division. अनुमानित लागत रुपये : 23,46,73,948.64 बयाने की राशि रुपये : 46,93,500.00 ई-निविदा सूचना सं. 2026-27 : 04 कार्य का नाम व स्थान : Provision of Lift on PF 01 & 02 of Salawas, Hanwant (02 No.). अनुमानित लागत रुपये : 1,59,94,019.50 बयाने की राशि रुपये : 3,19,900.00 ई-निविदा सूचना सं. 2026-27 : 05 कार्य का नाम व स्थान : Augmentation of minor Schedule facilities for Electric Locos in BGKT Diesel Shed. अनुमानित लागत रुपये : 129477055.88 बयाने की राशि रुपये : 2589600.00 निविदा सूचना संख्या एवं निविदा प्रस्तुत करने की तिथि GSU-01of2026-27 Date 04-05-2026, GSU-04of2026-27 Date 01-05-2026 & GSU-05of2026-27 Date 11-05-2026 को 15:00 बजे तक है। वेबसाइट का विवरण जहाँ पर ई-निविदा देखी व भरी जा सकती है - www.ireps.gov.in 536-CR/26

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EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

Open Tender Notice No: EL/Proj/DNR/ETEN/01/26-27

(1) Name of the work with its location: "Design, Supply, Erection, Testing and Commissioning Of 2x25 KV OHE modification Works to meet 3000MT loading target for UP & DN Line of Garhwa Road-Kumandhi Section of Dhanbad Division under E.C. Railway (Total 89/267 RKM/TKM)" (2) Approximate cost of the work: Rs.1014462832.57 (3) Cost of Tender form: Rs.0.00/- (4) Earnest money to be deposited: Rs.20289300.00/- (5) Date & time for submission of tender and opening of tender: Bidding start date 11.05.2026 and opening of tender on 25.05.2026 at 15.00 hrs. (6) Website particulars, notice board location where complete details of tender can be seen and address of the office from where the tender form can be purchased etc.: For eligibility criteria and other conditions and details, please go through the tender document available in web-site at <http://www.ireps.gov.in> (7) Address of the office from where the tender details can be obtained, website particulars and notice board location: Office of the Chief Electrical Engineer Railway Project, Danapur, Near Jagjeevan stadium, Khagaul, Danapur-801105 E-tendering website www.ireps.gov.in Notice board- Office of the Chief Electrical Engineer Railway Project, Danapur, Near Jagjeevan stadium, Khagaul, Danapur.

Dy. Chief Electrical Engineer Railway Project, Danapur

PR/0066/PROJECT/DNR/ELECT/7/26-27/44

CM

YK

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Tamil Nadu

INBRIEF



‘DMK failed to implement 10.5% quota for Vanniya

PMK president Anbumani Ramadoss on Tuesday said the DMK government was responsible for failing to implement the 10.5 % internal reservation for Vanniya

Ma. Aranganathan Literary Award to be given on April 16

Writer K. Vittal Rao and documentary film director Amshan Kumar have been selected for the Ma. Aranganathan Literary Award for 2026. The award will be presented to them at a function in Chennai on April 16.

TVK’s complete manifesto to be released tomorrow: Vijay

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI/TIRUPPUR

Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam founder and actor C. Joseph Vijay on Tuesday announced that the party’s complete election manifest

Campaigning at Perumanallur in Tiruppur district and unveiling excerpts from the TVK’s manifesto, he said: “I have come to repay a debt of gratitude. I will not deceive you by making false promises. Please consider me a family member and give me one chance.”

Mr. Vijay said a global e-commerce brand would be created to sell weavers’ products directly to international markets, alongside establishing sales outlets in major cities. The future TVK government, he said, would deposit ₹30,000 every year into the



Pitching reforms: TVK president C. Joseph Vijay greeting supporters on Coimbatore-Avinashi Road on Tuesday. M. PERIASAMY

bank account of every weaver family owning a handloom or power loom to tide over fluctuations in yarn prices and electricity. A 50% subsidy will be provided on yarn, dyes, and chemicals to cut down production costs; life insurance cover of ₹10 lakh will be extended per weaver; and old-age pension of weavers will be raised to ₹3,000 per month, he said.

Taking a dig at the DMK government, he said it had the distinction of placing Tamil Nadu second with

respect to closure of MSMEs. “This is their biggest achievement,” he said, promising creation of State Credit Guarantee Fund with a ₹15,000-crore allocation to revive the vibrancy of MSMEs.

As for the police, Mr. Vijay said the TVK government would increase the minimum basic monthly salary from ₹18,200 to ₹25,000. It will set up ‘Police Welfare Hospitals’ in Madurai, Coimbatore, Tirunelveli, Salem, and Vellore, he added.

Nadda releases BJP manifesto, says DMK rule has turned the State into crime capital

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Union Minister for Health and Family Welfare and former BJP national president J.P. Nadda on Tuesday alleged that the DMK government had converted Tamil Nadu, a cradle of the world’s oldest civilisation, into a “crime capital”.

Releasing the BJP’s manifesto for the Assembly elections in Tamil Nadu, where the party is contesting as a constituent of the AIADMK-led National Democratic Alliance, Mr. Nadda said every Indian is proud of Tamil Nadu. “We will always remember Saint Thiruvalluvar and Bharathiyar with reverence. But, under the DMK government, this cultural capital has been converted into a crime capital. Tamil



Poll promises: Union Minister J.P. Nadda releasing the BJP manifesto for Assembly elections in the presence of other senior party leaders in Chennai on Tuesday. S.R. RAGHUNATHAN

Nadu itself did not fail at any point of time, but it is the DMK that made it fail on all fronts,” he said.

“There is a lot of resentment against the DMK because of its dynastic and family rule, crime, and corruption. The resentment is against its allies, too. In this election, the people will expose their unholy alliance with the

DMK. The DMK has betrayed the faith of women, youth, farmers, the working class, and the marginalised sections,” he said.

The party’s promises have been broadly divided into 16 categories, while some of them have already been promised by the AIADMK, which leads the alliance.

The promises include

providing a monthly assistance of ₹2,000 to all women heads of households and a one-time sum of ₹10,000 to every household to offset inflation; three LPG cylinders free of cost, one each on the occasions of Pongal, Tamil New Year, and Deepavali; interest-free loans of up to ₹50 lakh for manufacturing units; declaring Thai Poosam the State festival; and ensuring the lighting of Karthigai Deepam atop the Thirupparankundram hill.

Among the other promises are the creation of a Tamil Nadu Drug Eradication Department with a specialised anti-narcotics task force and a ₹3,000 top-up to farmers under the Uzhave Thalai scheme over and above the ₹6,000 being given under the PM-KISAN scheme.

The Hindu Bureau
ANDIPATTI

AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami on Tuesday asked the farmers in Theni district if they wanted to re-elect the DMK, which has not done anything in the Mullaiperiyar dam issue.

Addressing an election meeting in Andipatti with ally and AMMK general secretary T.T.V. Dhinakaran, he said with a Communist Party of India (Marxist) government in Kerala, the Tamil Nadu government here could have worked wonders since they were alliance partners.

DMK president and Chief Minister M.K. Stalin was only interested in promoting his family and thus has neglected farmers. “If Amma [Jayalithaa] had not approached the Supreme Court, the storage level may not have even been increased from 136 ft to 142 ft. The DMK govern



Rallying call: Former Chief Minister Edappadi K. Palaniswami and AMMK general secretary T.T.V. Dhinakaran at a roadshow at Andipatti in Theni district on Tuesday. G. KARTHIKEYAN

ment should have taken it further to 152 ft or at least should have impressed upon the Kerala government to agree to 146 ft,” he argued.

Any rise in the storage level would help the farmers of five southern districts, including Theni, Mr. Palaniswami said, and promised that if the AIADMK was elected, he would

strive hard to get the storage level increased.

Attacking the DMK rule, he said Mr. Stalin was an opportunist. While the Congress and the Communists here in Tamil Nadu were allies in the DMK front, this was not the case in Kerala, where the parties were foes. Likewise, the Viduthalai Chiruthai Katchi (VCK) was also go

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Viduthalai Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK) founder Thol. Thirumavalavan on Tuesday released the party’s manifesto ahead of the Assembly elections.

Addressing journalists in Chennai, Mr. Thirumavalavan said the party would promote the two-language formula, protection of natural resources, separate law against caste-based murders, health as fundamental right, 50% reservations for women, reservations according to population, land to the tiller, and push for reforms in the police force and uniformed services, among other things.

“Instead of putting our demands in the form of a manifesto, we have put



Advocating social change: VCK president Thol. Thirumavalavan releasing the party manifesto in Chennai on Tuesday.

forth our ideological positions to bring about social change in the form of manifesto. Particularly, the BJP and the Sangh Parivar government in New Delhi is taking our country back to the dark ages and destroying the diversity of our country, especially with

laignar [M. Karunanidhi],” he said.

“I say it in the name of Ambedkar: if Tamil Nadu is affected, we will draw India’s attention. Prime Minister [Narendra Modi], this is the final warning from Tamil Nadu. Tamil Nadu will fight. Tamil Nadu will win,” he said.

Mr. Stalin said the DMK had warned about the implementation of delimitation from the beginning and created awareness among the people. The party had convened a meeting of Chief Ministers and leaders of political parties and formed a joint action committee. “We implemented the Centre’s advice on family planning and population control. Will you punish us for implementing your advice,” he asked.

Mr. Stalin said the southern States wanted an assurance from the Prime Minister that they would not be affected. “There has been no answer. We sought an appointment for MPs to meet the Prime Minister, but could not get it. They did not listen to us. Without consulting not only the DMK but also the other parties in all States, they are trying to do it according to their whim,” he said.

The Chief Minister also

pointed out that Congress leader Sonia Gandhi had raised the same questions.

“There has been no answer to anyone, including the Congress, the main Opposition party. It is a blatant violation of democracy on the part of the BJP government to implement delimitation in a hasty manner. In fact, it is a violation of the rights of the States,” he said.

Canvassing in Vellore

Speaking at a campaign meeting in Vellore later in the day, Mr. Stalin expressed concern over the proposed delimitation exercise, stating that it could adversely affect progressive States such as Tamil Nadu, which had effectively controlled population growth and achieved steady economic progress. He asserted that Tamil Nadu was not merely a geographical entity but the collective voice of 8 crore people, whose rights and self-respect could not be suppressed.

Questioning the timing of a possible Parliamentary exercise when some States were heading to polls, he said the DMK would oppose any delimitation Bill in Parliament. “The Prime Minister should not play with fire,” Mr. Stalin added.

Do you want to re-elect DMK for doing nothing about Mullaperiyar, Palaniswami asks farmers

ing it alone in Pudukcherry.

He appealed to the people of Tamil Nadu to realise that the members of the DMK-led alliance were nothing but a bunch of opportunists. To the crowd’s surprise, Mr. Palaniswami was silent on O. Panneerselvam, who is seeking re-election from Bodinayakanur on a DMK ticket. He simply said, “Yengiruthaalum Vaazhga” (Live well, wherever you are) and did not elaborate on it.

Pandemic management

Taking credit for the excellent management of the State during the COVID-19 pandemic when he was the Chief Minister, Mr. Palaniswami said they spent about ₹40,000 crore then. With no jobs, shops remaining closed, and people staying indoors, the government took good care of everyone. However, even with additional revenue pouring in now, the DMK regime had taken huge loans,

leaving the people in a big debt. Mr. Palaniswami said electricity charges had gone up by 67%, property tax rates had been increased by 100%, water connection charges had been raised from a meagre ₹900 (during the AIADMK regime) to ₹6,000 now per connection. “Isn’t it atrocious? Do you still want this party (DMK) to come back?” he asked the crowd and urged them to vote them out of power. “We will bring back the lost sheen,” he assured them.

Introducing the candidates – A. Logirajan (AIADMK), Kathirkamu (AMMK in Periyakulam (SC)), V.T. Duraisamy (Bodinayakanur), and S.T.K. Jakkayan (Cumbum) – Mr. Palaniswami asserted that Theni district had been proudly known from time immemorial as the AIADMK’s fort since both their late leaders – MGR and Jayalithaa – were elected from here.

VCK manifesto voices against delimitation proposal, promotes two-language formula

Mr. Thirumavalavan added: “They are doing it when Assembly election campaigns are in full swing in Tamil Nadu and West Bengal, so as to ensure the certain MPs would be unable to attend.”

He added, if the constitution needed to be amended, the BJP-led alliance needed a two-third majority, and they had planned the session in such a manner that they could achieve it.

“They are doing it to ensure a two-third majority. This is a violation. We appeal to the BJP to hold this session after the Assembly elections. They have gone against standard procedure and have not shared any information regarding the agenda for the session,” Mr. Thirumavalavan added.

policies such as ‘one nation, one election’. They are moving their pieces to achieve that. They have called for a special session of Parliament to push through amendments to facilitate the delimitation exercise and reservations for women,” he said.



Reservation ruse

Women’s empowerment is an excuse to undermine federal equity

In a Parliament sitting convened from April 16, the Union government is seeking to advance women’s empowerment, but as part of a wider legislative package: the Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill, 2026, and a companion Delimitation Bill. The stated rationale is the operationalisation of the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam (the 106th Amendment of 2023), which reserves one-third of Lok Sabha and Assembly seats for women but was tied to a post-Census delimitation. The government’s insistence on bundling women’s reservation with delimitation suggests that the former is being used as political cover for the latter: a sweeping reallocation of Lok Sabha seats that would reshape the federal composition of Parliament to the advantage of States where the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) enjoys electoral dominance, and at the expense of States where it has been historically weak.

When India’s decennial Census was delayed for more than five years without a definitive or rational explanation from the BJP-led Union government, the political logic was not hard to discern. The 2021 Census was first postponed citing COVID-19, but no reason was offered for the successive deferrals that followed, until it was quietly announced that the exercise would be carried out in 2026-27. Under the Constitution, the freeze on inter-State distribution of Lok Sabha seats, pegged to the 1971 Census, was set to expire only after the first Census conducted after the year 2026 was published. This meant that in the normal course, delimitation would have been based on the 2031 Census. By delaying the Census to 2026-27, the government ensured that the delimitation exercise could be initiated on its preferred timeline, using the 2026-27 Census rather than one conducted in 2031.

Now, perhaps realising that any delimitation exercise would itself take years to conclude after the 2026-27 Census, and therefore not be ready even for the 2029 Lok Sabha elections, the government appears to be in a tearing hurry to proceed with delimitation on the basis of the last completed Census, that of 2011. The 131st Amendment Bill amends Articles 55, 81, 82, 170, 330, 332, and 334A of the Constitution. Its most consequential changes are the following. First, it raises the ceiling on Lok Sabha membership from 530 elected members from States and 20 from Union Territories to 815 and 35 respectively, to a potential House of 850. Second, it replaces the existing constitutional definition of “population”, which specifies the 1971 Census for seat allocation and the 2001 Census for boundary demarcation, with an open-ended formulation: population shall mean the Census “as Parliament may by law determine.” The choice of which Census to use is no longer left to the Constitution but will depend on ordinary legislation, changeable by simple majority. Third, it deletes the third proviso to Articles 82 and 170 entirely. A freeze on seat allocation that has been in place since the 42nd Amendment of 1976, and extended by the 84th Amendment of 2001, guaranteed States that had stabilised their populations that they would not lose parliamentary seats as a consequence. This safeguard is now removed.

Members of the Union Cabinet, including Home Minister Amit Shah and Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal, had assured the country that the existing proportion of seats held by each State will be maintained through a uniform increase. But this assurance finds no place in the constitutional amendment. Article 81(2)(a), retained unchanged, mandates that the ratio between seats and population shall be the same for all States “so far as practicable” which is a population-proportionality requirement and does not preserve existing proportions.

Based on 2011 Census data, a purely population-proportional allocation to an 850-seat House would produce sharply unequal increases across regions. The Hindi-heartland States (Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, Haryana, Chhattisgarh, Uttarakhand, and Delhi), which currently hold 207 of 543 seats, would secure 366 – a 77% increase, with their share rising from 38.1% to 43.1%. The southern States (Tamil Nadu, Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, Kerala, and Puducherry), with 132 seats now, would receive only 176, a 33% increase, while their share would drop from 24.3% to 20.7%. The eastern States would slip from 14.4% to 13.7%; the North-East from 4.4% to 3.8%. The west and the northern non-Hindi States would remain roughly unchanged. States that spent decades building their health infrastructure, educational access, and women’s agency that brought fertility down now face a reduction in their share of democratic power, while States that lagged on these indicators stand to gain the most seats. The already weakened fiscal federalism would now be compounded by diminished political representation for socio-economically advanced States.

That this legislation is being rushed through, with barely any time for public debate, just days before voters in two crucial States go to the polls, makes the timing even more suspect. There is no reason why women’s reservation cannot be implemented within the existing 543-seat Lok Sabha by designating constituencies for women on a rotational basis, an approach the Opposition had pressed for after the passage of the 106th Amendment. MPs from States that stand to lose proportional representation in the Lok Sabha must resist the bulldozing of legislation on an issue that strikes at the federal foundations of the Indian Union. The consequences of letting this amendment pass are too grave to contemplate.

The recent announcement by Air India, hinting at possible pay cuts or even de-rostering for crew members with a higher Body Mass Index (BMI), may, at first glance, appear to be a prudent and well-intentioned step toward ensuring fitness and operational safety. Aviation, after all, is a profession where physical readiness is essential. Yet, the timing of this decision –coinciding with the week an anti-obesity drug, semaglutide, went off patent and nearly 40 products entered the Indian market– signals something deeper.

India today faces a mounting burden of obesity and associated metabolic conditions such as diabetes, hypertension, fatty liver disease, and dyslipidaemia. Nearly a quarter of Indians are overweight or obese. One in 10 adults live with diabetes, one in three with hypertension, and a substantial proportion has fatty liver disease. Even more concerning is the rapid rise of obesity among children. The causes, which are neither obscure nor debated, include the proliferation of ultra-processed or high fat, salt and sugar-content foods, and increasingly sedentary lifestyles shaped by urban work patterns, shrinking open spaces, chronic stress, alcohol consumption, and inadequate sleep. Compounding this is a genetic predisposition among Indians and South Asians toward excess body fat despite a seemingly lean appearance – the so-called “thin-fat” phenotype.

Historically, in a society long shaped by undernutrition and micronutrient deficiencies, excess weight was once perceived as a marker of prosperity. Consequently, as overweight and obesity began rising over the past two decades, public discourse remained muted, almost reluctant to confront this emerging reality.

Then came the pharmaceutical response. Around this time last year, another anti-obesity drug, tirzepatide, entered the Indian market and rapidly became one of its highest-selling medications. Its commercial success revealed not just clinical demand but also the emergence of a vast and lucrative therapeutic marketplace. With semaglutide now available at a remarkably lower cost, the market potential has expanded further.

Sustained marketing campaign

Over the past year, however, a more troubling pattern has emerged. Prescription medicines cannot be directly advertised to the public, yet pharmaceutical companies have grown adept at navigating these constraints. Surrogate advertising – often framed as public awareness campaigns – has become increasingly sophisticated. In the past year, the country witnessed full page newspaper campaigns, and billboards at major urban areas regarding obesity;



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One of the most fundamental drivers of the obesity epidemic – the expansion of ultra-processed foods –receives comparatively limited attention

Mapping the legislative vacuum in India’s heat crisis

The phenomenon of extreme heat in India has undergone a profound geographic and demographic shift, transitioning from a seasonal hardship to a systemic national crisis. Once confined largely to the arid northwest and central plains, heatwaves now regularly penetrate humid coastal corridors and traditionally temperate regions. The last two years recorded unprecedented temperatures, with over 57% of Indian districts now classified as heat-prone. However, while the thermal canopy covers the entire subcontinent, its impact is sharply divided by class, caste, and gender. For the affluent, heat is an inconvenience managed through private cooling; for the nearly 400-490 million informal workers, it is a systemic violation of the right to life and a driver of “thermal injustice.”

Unlike those with private infrastructure, construction workers, street vendors, and delivery partners possess zero “cooling autonomy.” For these individuals, as studies consistently demonstrate, even a small rise in temperature causes a significant drop in productivity and a corresponding loss of income. These workers are routinely forced to choose between their biological survival and their economic survival.

Evidence from the frontlines

Recent evidence from the frontlines has yielded harrowing testimonies of harm that underscore this inequality. Sanitation workers and waste pickers report that extreme ambient heat, combined with toxic fumes from unsegregated waste, creates hazardous micro-climates where temperatures can be up to 5% higher than in surrounding areas. Some workers have reported suffering severe physical burns on their hands and legs due to handling heated waste materials without protective gear. This ‘climate-caste nexus’ ensures that those in the most dehumanising roles are also the most exposed to lethal heat, yet



Bhoomika Choudhury

Independent researcher and adviser on business and human rights, migration and labour rights

The government should launch suitable provisions for financial compensation to cover the loss of income incurred when heat extremes prevent work

influencer endorsements for medical products; and sponsored features that resemble independent journalism, subtly shape public perception without explicitly naming the drugs.

Regulatory responses lagged behind. The restraint from the government on newspaper ads and billboards came only a year later.

The messaging on drugs from pharmaceuticals is rarely overt; instead, it is nuanced, persistent, and highly effective, gradually reshaping both public expectations and clinical practice. In such an environment, the boundary between genuine scientific advancement and commercial enthusiasm begins to blur. New drugs are presented as transformative breakthroughs, while their uncertainties receive far less attention.

The less talked about side effects

Anti-obesity medications, particularly those acting on GLP-1 pathways, are associated not only with fat loss but also with a reduction in lean muscle mass – a condition known as sarcopenia. As there is loss of fat from the body, nearly 25% to 40% is contributed by the loss of muscle mass – an unintended but serious consequence. By suppressing appetite and reducing caloric intake, these drugs can inadvertently lead to muscle loss unless accompanied by adequate protein intake and structured physical activity, especially resistance training. Sarcopenia in this context is no longer a theoretical concern. It has been documented in clinical trials and is supported by emerging real-world evidence. Yet, amid the celebration of weight loss outcomes, such risks are often understated. Individuals may achieve a lower BMI while compromising strength, metabolic resilience, and long-term health.

The trajectory does not end there. Sarcopenia itself is now emerging as a new therapeutic target. Pharmaceutical pipelines already include drugs aimed at preventing or reversing muscle loss, many in advanced stages of development. It requires little imagination to foresee the next phase – a population using anti-obesity medicines, along with additional therapies to manage the very consequences these drugs produce. What we are witnessing here is a cascading logic: one intervention begets another, each addressing the unintended consequences of the previous one. It is a self-reinforcing cycle sustained by scientific innovation, commercial incentives, and a growing societal preference for quick pharmacological solutions over sustained behavioural change.

Perhaps what is most disquieting is the evolving role of professional medical bodies within this ecosystem both globally, and increasingly in India. Clinical guidelines are being

they remain largely excluded from existing adaptation strategies.

These vulnerabilities are seen across sectors. Gig delivery partners operate under “algorithmic pressure” where time-sensitive penalties discourage rest even during red-alert periods. Construction workers face high metabolic heat generated by physical exertion, compounded by the heat from steel and concrete. Street vendors face the double blow of health deterioration and a drop in daily income as goods perish and customers retreat.

A profound legal and fiscal vacuum exacerbates this crisis. The Factories Act, 1948 protects only those in indoor “workrooms,” while the new Occupational Safety, Health and Working Conditions (OSHC) Code 2020 essentially erases outdoor heat. Although Section 23 of the Code allows the government to notify standards for weather, it does not mandate them, vesting the Centre with discretionary authority and no minimum safety floor.

And fiscally, since heatwaves are not currently on the Nationally Notified Disaster list, States are restricted by the ‘10% trap’, where they can only utilise a small fraction of their State Disaster Response Fund for relief efforts.

However, from a worker’s perspective, the issue remains one of occupational safety rather than just disaster management.

Addressing ‘thermal injustice’

A comprehensive framework for legislative and executive action is required to bridge these gaps and transition from discretionary advisories to enforceable rights. This must begin with the formal acceptance of the 16th Finance Commission’s recommendation to include heatwaves and lightning in the Notified National Disaster list for the 2026-31 period. Such a move would unlock the National Disaster Response Fund, bypass current spending restrictions, and

updated with growing frequency, sometimes annually, often generating anticipation around new therapies. The interval between a drug’s introduction and its inclusion in standard treatment protocols appears to be shrinking. Inclusion in such guidelines almost guarantees widespread adoption and commercial success. While scientific progress must be embraced, the pace of endorsement raises important questions: are these recommendations grounded in robust, long-term evidence, or are they shaped by the forces influencing markets and public discourse?

Meanwhile, one of the most fundamental drivers of the obesity epidemic – the rapid expansion of ultra-processed foods –receives comparatively limited attention. In India, this sector has grown at an annual rate of around 13% between 2011 and 2021. These products, aggressively marketed and widely accessible, shape dietary habits from an early age, fuelling the very conditions the pharmaceutical industry seeks to treat. Yet policy responses remain hesitant. Front-of-package warning labels, for instance, continue to face delays.

Thus, we inhabit a deeply paradoxical ecosystem. One industry promotes consumption patterns that drive metabolic disease. Another offers pharmaceutical remedies. A third emerges to treat the side effects of those remedies. From a market perspective, this system is efficient, profitable, and self-sustaining. From a public health perspective, it is profoundly misaligned with the goal of durable well-being.

Shift in perspective

Reclaiming the narrative of health demands a shift in perspective. Medicines must be recognised as adjuncts, and not substitutes, for foundational interventions such as a nourishing diet, increased physical activity, sufficient and restorative sleep, and stress management. Greater transparency about the risks of newer therapies is not just desirable but absolutely essential. At the same time, there must be stronger, evidence-based advocacy to restore lifestyle modification to the centre of clinical care. The medical profession must, above all, reaffirm its ethical compass.

Encouraging fitness among airline crew is not misguided. But if such measures become yet another entry point into a cycle of measurement, medication, and market-driven dependence, we risk losing sight of what health truly means. Anti-obesity drugs are not the destination; they are a signal revealing how deeply medicalisation is embedding itself into everyday life. This is a moment to pause, recalibrate, and reclaim health before medicine begins to define it.

convert early warnings from simple advisories into binding mandates for district administrations. Simultaneously, the Ministry of Labour and the India Meteorological Department must transition to the Heat Index, a metric combining temperature and relative humidity to reflect true human feel, as the primary legal trigger for declaring heatwaves. This is essential to ensure that coastal areas, which face the lethal combination of heat and humidity, are not at a disadvantage in national safety protocols.

Furthermore, the government must exercise its powers under Section 23 of the OSHWC Code to notify binding heat safety rules, including protected work-rest cycles, and the provision of specialised Personal Protective Equipment (PPE) such as insulated flasks, as a non-negotiable employer obligation. Based on the Supreme Court’s *Ranjitsinh* (2024) ruling, the ‘Right to Cool’ must be recognised as a fundamental right under Article 21, necessitating that Urban Local Bodies establish suitable cooling shelters and free public water kiosks.

Specialised binding directives are needed for high-hazard occupations, such as sanitation and underground mining, to mitigate risks from toxic exposure. For the gig economy, digital platforms should be legally prohibited from imposing delivery time penalties during heat alerts, ensuring a statutory thermal safety net for workers currently excluded due to their ‘contractor’ status. Finally, the government should launch suitable provisions for financial compensation to cover the loss of income incurred when heat extremes prevent work. Innovative models, such as the Self-Employed Women’s Association parametric heat insurance scheme, provide a viable blueprint for this transition. Heat governance must be reimaged as a core component of the social contract where thermal safety is a non-negotiable mandate of constitutional justice.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

On the right to vote

The Supreme Court’s remark to the Election Commission that voting is a “sentimental right” is a timely reminder of its true essence. Voting is not just a procedural formality; it embodies citizens’ faith, dignity, and voice in a democracy. Any attempt to dilute its value – through restrictive measures, lack of transparency, or administrative lapses – risks eroding public trust.

The Election Commission must treat this right with the seriousness it deserves by ensuring absolute fairness, accessibility, and accountability in the electoral process. Protecting the sanctity of voting is not optional; it is imperative for sustaining a healthy and inclusive democracy.
Nagarajamani M.V.
Telangana

Remembering Ambedkar
The SIR which was

supposed to be a credible exercise in electoral hygiene is now turning out into a facade. On Ambedkar Jayanti, it is pertinent to note that the Father of our Constitution strongly advocated for universal adult franchise, viewing the right to vote as essential to democratic equality.
Biju C. Mathew
Thiruvananthapuram

Thumping victory
Hungary’s recent verdict

offers a lesson that resonates far beyond its borders. After sixteen years of uninterrupted rule – marked by constitutional changes that favoured those in power and a steady weakening of institutional checks – voters chose to bring about a decisive shift. The scale of this outcome itself underlines the resilience of democratic will. It also highlights a broader pattern: populist politics has its limits. Appeals to

nationalism and the creation of perceived enemies may work for a time, but they lose force when everyday concerns such as economic slowdown and falling living standards begin to dominate public thinking. The Hungarian experience reinforces a core democratic truth: no matter how entrenched a government may seem, it is never beyond the reach of an electorate to demand

accountability and change.
A. Myilsami
Coimbatore



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Food worth ₹1.55 lakh cr. wasted annually

Each year, on March 30, the world marks the International Day of Zero Waste. This year, the theme is food waste, which is not only timely but also an emergency call for global attention to one of the most painful contradictions of our time: mountains of food going waste even as millions go to bed hungry and malnutrition prevails across the globe.

The United Nations Environment Programme (UNEP) Food Waste Index Report 2024 finds that the world wasted 1.05 billion tonnes of food – inadequate post-harvest storage capacities and households accounting for 60% of it, food services 28%, and retail 12%. Beyond individual behaviour, the scale of food loss reflects systemic inefficiencies embedded in supply chains, policy failures, and consumption cultures that have normalised discarding food as an acceptable cost of abundance.

Yet, abundance is far from universal; around 783 million people still face hunger, and more than 3.1 billion are unable to afford a healthy diet. The coexistence of a billion tonnes of wasted food and a billion hungry stomachs is not an irony; it is an indictment of inefficiency and apathy.

India's position in the global picture is both consequential and deeply uncomfortable. According to the UNEP report, India ranks second globally in food waste, with 78-80 million tonnes of post-harvest crop and food worth ₹1.55 lakh crore wasted annually, following China, which wastes an estimated 108 million tonnes of food per year. At the same time, the U.S. wastes 24.7 million tonnes annually. Japan, which is long celebrated for its culture of 'mottainai' – a deep-rooted ethic of zero waste, wastes merely 5.2 million tonnes of food annually.

The per capita picture is equally revealing. Per capita household food waste in India stands at 55 kg annually, lower than 73 kg in the U.S. and 75 kg in Germany. The country ranks 111th



A.S. Mittal

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Board

out of 125 countries in the Global Hunger Index and around 194 million of its people do not get enough food. Food waste is not a statistic; it is stolen meals from millions of mouths.

Punjab is a State that produces enough to feed hundreds of millions but then watches a significant portion of that go to waste before it reaches plates. Food loss and waste in the State is a significant issue, driven by extreme weather events and alarming levels of inefficiencies in storage and logistics. With over 8,200 tonnes of foodgrains getting spoiled in Food Corporation of India storage facilities alone in the State between 2019 and 2024, it is the highest in India.

According to a NITI Aayog report, post-harvest handling inefficiencies – inadequate covered storage facilities, under-investment in cold-chain infrastructure and timely mechanisation support, and the lack of grading, standardisation, and scientific packaging – are major bottlenecks in Punjab.

Food waste is not merely a human tragedy; it is an ecological one. Food loss and waste account for 8-10% of global annual greenhouse gas emissions. If food waste were a country, it would be the third-largest emitter of greenhouse gases after China and the U.S. Decomposing food in landfills releases methane, which has a warming potential many times more than that of CO₂.

Every morsel wasted means lost water, land, fuel, and hard work of farmers. Producing one kilogram of rice requires about 5,000 litres of water. When that rice is thrown away, the water is lost too, more so for a State like Punjab which faces groundwater depletion. In this context, integrating food loss and waste into national climate plans is urgent.

Ending food waste demands a reconfiguration of systems, incentives, and values, with human dignity at their centre. The following are five credible and sustainable ways in that direction:

Build the cold chain, break the loss chain: India processes only around 8% of its produce compared to 65% of the U.S. and 23% of China. A national cold-chain mission, particularly in States such as Punjab, Haryana, and U.P., must be treated as food security infrastructure, not an optional investment.

Legislate against waste, legislate for sharing: Several European nations have made it illegal for supermarkets to destroy unsold edible food, mandating its donation to food banks instead. India needs a law to redistribute surplus food, backed by tax incentives for businesses and institutions that donate.

Empower the farmer at the first mile: Post-harvest loss begins at the farm gate. Farmer-producer organisations must be equipped with mechanised drying, hermetic storage bags, and mobile cold units. The Jute Packaging Materials Act, which requires grain storage in porous jute sacks, needs to be urgently reviewed to allow modern hermetic solutions.

Make waste visible, make saving rewarding: India currently has no consolidated national database tracking food waste at the retail and hospitality level. Mandatory food waste measurement and public reporting, modelled on the UNEP's Food Waste Index methodology, should be introduced for large food businesses, wedding caterers, and institutional kitchens.

Revive the ethic of treating 'Anna (food)' as sacred: Every culture on this subcontinent has, in its own way, treated food as something to be revered – *Anna Brahma*, food is god. It is the most sustainable food philosophy ever devised. Schools, communities, and public institutions must rekindle this ethic, not as religious instruction but as civic responsibility.

Let's move from awareness to collective action and make food waste reduction a shared national priority.

A promising hate speech Bill, with gaps

The Assembly select committee should redraft it to evolve into a balanced law

STATE OF PLAY

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Over 100 days ago, at a pre-Christmas celebration, Telangana Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy announced plans to introduce legislation on hate speech to punish those who insult other religions. Keeping his word, the Chief Minister ensured that the Telangana Hate Speech and Hate Crimes (Prevention) Bill, 2026 was introduced in the Assembly on March 30, 2026. While the intent of the government was to ensure respect for all faiths and strictly deal with attempts to disrupt communal harmony, the Bill's operative portions sparked intense debate.

Drawing flak from political parties as well as religious minority groups, the government referred the Bill to a select committee. In simple terms, the Bill defines hate speech broadly as any expression – spoken, written, or digital – intended to cause “disharmony” or “ill-will” based on religion, caste, gender, or sexual orientation. It includes stringent provisions, such as imprisonment ranging from one to seven years for first-time offenders and up to 10 years for repeat offenders. Curiously, the Bill classifies these offences as cognizable and non-bailable, effectively allowing the police to arrest individuals without a warrant.

It also empowers a “Designated Officer” to block or remove digital content from social media platforms without a prior court order or hearing – a move critics have termed “digital authoritarianism.”

Political parties critical of the government flayed the Bill for allowing arrests without



bail and for creating a censorship mechanism which, they argue, operates without judicial supervision.

BRS working president K.T. Rama Rao described it as a draconian tool that could be misused against citizens and political opponents, while BJP floor leader A. Maheshwari Reddy termed it a “death warrant” for freedom of speech. AIMIM legislator Ahmed Bin Balala argued that propagation of religion should not be treated as hate speech, noting that existing laws already cover such offences. CPI MLA Kunnamneni Sambasiva Rao said the Bill was an attack on democracy, reminiscent of colonial-era laws.

But, Transport Minister Ponnam Prabhakar, who introduced the Bill in the Assembly, defended it, describing it as a safeguard for vulnerable groups rather than a curb on free speech. Chief Minister Revanth Reddy also rejected allegations of political vendetta. He argued that existing legislation cannot match the speed and scale of online hate speech and insisted that a comprehensive new framework is essential to maintain public order and protect marginalised communities.

Civil society organisations, however, offered a more nuanced assessment. Civil Rights Initiative Internationale (CRII), a Hyderabad-based NGO focused on protecting civil rights, has documented over

42 incidents of targeted violence and discrimination across Telangana, raising concerns about constitutional freedoms and minority rights. Dr. K. Babu Rao, former Additional Director General of Police and national president of CRII, highlighted physical assaults, vandalism, and inflammatory rhetoric against minority communities, pointing to systemic exclusion and discriminatory practices.

Goneh Solomon Raj, general secretary of the Telangana United Christians and Pastors Association (TUCPA), which represents churches across 594 mandals, reported that six Christian places of worship were attacked in January this year alone.

Mazher Hussain, founder and executive director of Confederation of Voluntary Associations (COVA), said a law against hate speech and hate crimes was long overdue and cited NCRB data showing that Hyderabad topped communal cases for three years till 2021.

Senior High Court Advocate C.R. Sukumar praised the Bill's intent to curb inflammatory speech but warned of serious flaws. He noted that vague definitions of “hate speech” and unchecked executive powers could turn it into a tool against dissent, journalists, and citizens, undermining free speech under Article 19(1)(a). While acknowledging its protective aim in a polarised society, Mr. Sukumar cautioned that its overbreadth risks weaponisation.

With careful redrafting, the Bill could evolve into a balanced law that genuinely protects communities while respecting fundamental freedoms. Without such correction, it risks becoming an example of how good intentions can result in bad legislation.

Consumption growth uneven among largely rural States

Differences across States indicate that growth is becoming increasingly State-specific, shaped by local economic conditions and structural factors

DATA POINT

Chandrasekar K.

In India, consumption is primarily being driven by cities, where higher incomes, better job opportunities and faster economic activity lead to stronger spending growth (**Chart 1**). However, this narrative does not fully capture the reality in States such as Bihar, Chhattisgarh, Himachal Pradesh, Jharkhand, Madhya Pradesh, Odisha, Rajasthan, and Uttar Pradesh, where more than 70% of the population resides in rural areas, except North East States and Union Territories. In these States, rural households play a crucial role in the economy, making it more meaningful to compare these States with each other rather than with more urbanised States.

A State with low initial consumption may show higher growth simply because it is in a catching-up phase. A simple example shows why such comparisons need care. A student improving from 25 marks to 30 marks shows a higher percentage increase than one moving from 95 to 97, yet the latter clearly performs better. By focusing exclusively on States with predominantly rural populations, the analysis allows for a more equitable comparison and offers a clearer picture of their relative performance in consumption growth.

This analysis uses Monthly Per Capita Consumption Expenditure (MPCE) data from the Household Consumption Expenditure Survey (HCES) reports for 2011-12 and 2023-24 to examine how consumption patterns have evolved in rural-dominated States. The growth rates discussed are presented in real terms, meaning they have been adjusted for inflation. This adjustment is achieved using Consumer Price Index data, which removes the effects of rising prices over time. Without this adjustment, increases in consumption could reflect higher prices rather

than actual improvements in spending power. By converting nominal expenditure into real terms, this analysis provides a clearer understanding of how consumption levels have genuinely changed between 2011-12 and 2023-24.

The differences across States become clearer when we look at individual performance (**Chart 2**).

Bihar emerges as the leading performer among rural-dominated States. Rural consumption rose from ₹1,127 in 2011-12 to ₹3,670 in 2023-24, demonstrating significant nominal growth. After adjusting for inflation, it has expanded at a real rate of 4.7% annually, considerably higher than the all-India rural average of 3.4%. Urban consumption has also gone up swiftly at 4.6%, well above the national average of 2.9%. This shows that Bihar is not merely catching up from a low starting point but is also experiencing widespread growth in both rural and urban sectors.

In Odisha, Rural MPCE has grown at 4.5% while urban consumption has grown at 4.0%, both comfortably above the national averages. This suggests that Odisha is experiencing balanced and robust consumption growth, with urban areas showing a slight edge.

In Himachal Pradesh, rural consumption has grown at 4.0% and urban consumption at 3.7%, both above the national average in real terms. This reflects a stable and well-distributed growth pattern without sharp divergence between rural and urban areas.

In Jharkhand and Madhya Pradesh, rural consumption has grown at 3.8%, above the national rural average. However, urban consumption growth is 2.9%, same as the all-India average. This suggests moderate and stable growth, with rural areas performing slightly better than urban areas.

Uttar Pradesh shows a mixed pattern. In real terms, the rural consumption has grown at 3.8%, above the national average. However, urban consumption growth is 2.8%, slightly below the all-India

urban average. This suggests that while rural areas are contributing to the growth, urban areas are limiting the overall momentum.

Rajasthan's rural consumption growth stands at 3.4%, equal to the national average, while urban growth at 3.0% is slightly above the all-India average. This indicates balanced, non-leading performance.

In Chhattisgarh, rural consumption growth is 3.1%, below the national average, while urban growth is 3.2%, above it. This suggests that urban areas are pulling ahead while rural consumption lags.

A useful way to interpret these trends is through a quadrant framework based on the all-India average. States such as Bihar and Odisha fall in the high-growth quadrant, indicating strong and balanced performance across both rural and urban areas. Himachal Pradesh also shows steady progress above national averages. In contrast, Jharkhand, Madhya Pradesh, and Uttar Pradesh show stronger rural growth than urban areas, suggesting that rural demand is driving overall consumption. Chhattisgarh shows the opposite pattern, where urban growth exceeds rural growth. Meanwhile, Rajasthan lies close to national averages, reflecting steady but not leading performance.

A notable aspect of the data is that rural consumption growth now matches or even exceeds urban growth in several States, reversing the traditional pattern in which cities led demand. This suggests that the constraint on overall consumption growth may lie more in urban moderation than in rural weakness. Still, differences across States indicate that growth is becoming increasingly State-specific, shaped by local economic conditions and structural factors. These trends collectively indicate a changing consumption landscape in which rural India is not only catching up but also playing a central role in driving demand.

(The writer is an Indian Statistical Service Officer. Views are personal.)

Uneven gains

The data for the charts were sourced from the HCES Reports for 2011-12 & 2023-24 from Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation



CHART 1: Average Monthly Per Capita Consumer Expenditure (MPCE) (in ₹) at nominal price in urban and rural areas over the years

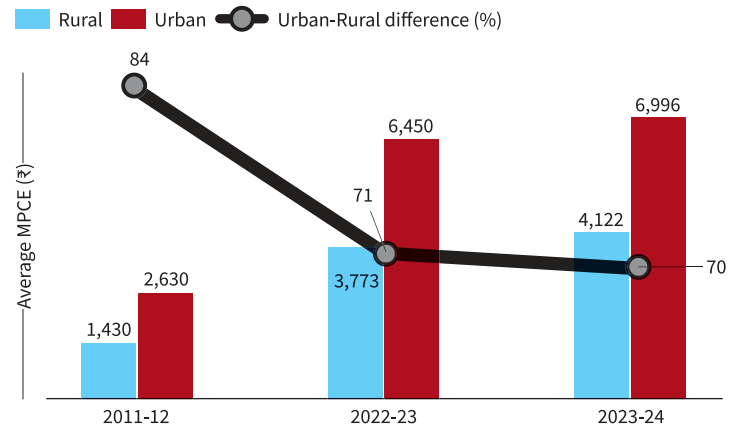
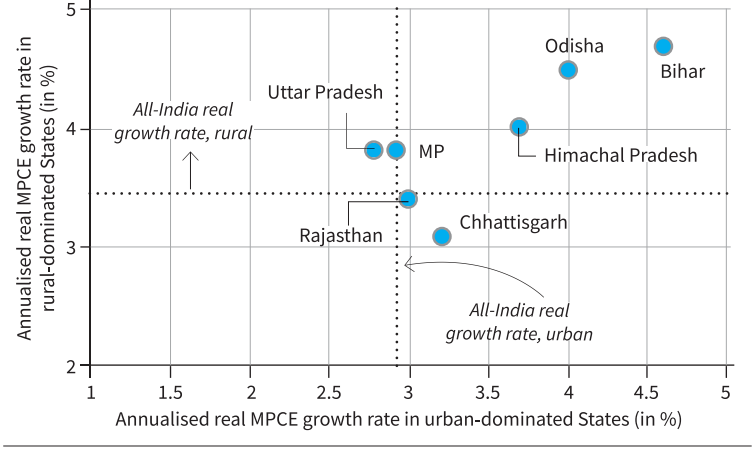


CHART 2: Annualised real MPCE growth rate in rural-dominated States (in %) on the X-axis and annualised real MPCE growth rate in urban-dominated States (in %) on the Y-axis



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The  **Hindu.**

FIFTY YEARS AGO APRIL 15, 1976

Krishna water for Madras: Accord signed in Delhi

New Delhi, April 14: A formal agreement to supply 15 tmc. ft. of water from the Krishna river to Madras was to-day formally signed at an inter-ministerial meeting held under the chairmanship of the Union Minister of Agriculture, Mr. Jagjivan Ram.

The Prime Minister had, during her visit to Madras in February, announced the willingness of Andhra Pradesh, Maharashtra and Karnataka to supply 5 tmc. ft. each from their share of the Krishna waters to meet the chronic drinking-water shortage in Madras. The agreement signed to-day is in pursuance of this announcement.

The meeting was attended by the Ministers in charge of Irrigation of Maharashtra and Karnataka. Mr. J. Vengal Rao, Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister could not attend but had informed the Union Minister that he stood by the commitment already made. The agreement will be forwarded to him for formal approval.

A significant feature of the agreement is that the respective States would supply the specified quantity notwithstanding the nature of the verdict of the Krishna River Waters Dispute Tribunal. The verdict is expected in the next few weeks. The dispute relating to the sharing of the Krishna waters by Maharashtra, Andhra Pradesh and Karnataka had been referred to a tribunal which gave its verdict, but the matter has not been finalised since the States have asked for clarifications.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO APRIL 15, 1926

Food value of rice

Finest grades grown at Patna

A “Times” Special Service cable to “The Statesman” under date London, April 13th, states:—

The British public buys rice by outward appearance only, ignoring the fact that all cleaned rice has the same food value, writes Douglas Glennie in an illuminating article in “The Times” on Indian rice crops.

He asserts that it is a curious psychological fact that nine out of ten housewives, if asked where rice is produced, reply “India,” yet they demand Japanese rice from their grocers. He points out Rangoon for cheap grade rice, Bassein for something better and Patna for the finest product.

WS
M CH-CH_E

Officials told to visit vulnerable areas in Bengal

▼ The West Bengal government on Tuesday directed district administrations and the police to jointly visit vulnerable areas within the next three days ahead of the Assembly election, an official said.

In a letter, Chief Secretary Dushyant Nariala asks District Magistrates (DMs), Commissioners of Police (CPs)

and Superintendents of Police (SPs) to identify localities that witnessed incidents of violence or intimidation during previous elections.

“Such places should be visited within the next 2-3 days by DMs/DEOs along with CPs/SPs and District Force Coordinators,” the letter said, adding that the visits should be covered by the press.

An official said the objective is to reassure voters and ensure a peaceful atmosphere in identified pockets. P71



The objective of the visits is to boost public confidence before the Assembly election. ANI

2,926 people to contest in West Bengal polls

▼ A total of 2,926 candidates are in the fray in the 294 constituencies in the upcoming West Bengal Assembly election.

The Assembly polls would be held in two phases in West Bengal on April 23 and April 29. While 1,487 candidates will contest 152 seats for Phase 1, in Phase 2, a total of 1,448

contestants will fight in 142 constituencies.

The last date for filing nominations for the polls in West Bengal was April 9 and the last date for withdrawal of nominations was April 13.

Citizens can view the details of their candidates including their educational qualifications, criminal antecedents, assets and liabilities and download their affidavits from the “Know Your Candidate” tab on the ECINet App, the EC said in a statement.



●● BJP has persecuted Bengali-speaking people in BJP-ruled States. They have belittled our culture, and conspired to rob people's rights

ABHISHEK BANERJEE
Trinamool Congress leader

'EC singled out Trinamool leaders'

▼ The Trinamool Congress on Tuesday alleged that only its leaders, specifically Abhishek Banerjee, have been “singled out for intrusive checks” of their vehicles by security personnel, based on “targeted instructions” from the Election Commission. The poll body has not yet responded to the allegations. P71



●● Press the EVM buttons next to the lotus sign so hard in regions of north Bengal so that infiltrators across India can feel the electric shock

AMIT SHAH
Union Home Minister



Congress leader Rahul Gandhi addresses a public meeting, in Murshidabad on Tuesday. ANI

Trinamool paved way for BJP in Bengal, says Rahul

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Tuesday addressed three public meetings in poll-bound West Bengal, accusing the Trinamool Congress of paving the way for the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) in the State.

“The BJP spreads violence. Their Prime Minister is ‘compromised’. I won’t even talk about them. On the other hand, the Trinamool has paved the way for the BJP in West Bengal. Because, if the Trinamool had done its work, provided for your income, and didn’t spread violence, the BJP wouldn’t have been seen here,” Mr. Gandhi said.

He addressed election meetings at Uttar Dinajpur, Malda and Murshidabad districts and sought support for his party candidates. The Congress leader was canvassing for his party’s candidates after five years since the Assembly polls in 2021.

‘Industries destroyed’

Speaking at a meeting at Raiganj in Uttar Dinajpur, Mr. Gandhi accused Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee of destroying industries in the State, and alleged that Prime Minister Narendra Modi is also trying to do the same in the entire country.

“West Bengal was earlier a hub of industry. The Left and then Mamata Banerjee have ruined the entire industry of the State. If we talk about violence, about atrocities on women, then we have to talk about rape and murder. There is no accountability in West Bengal. The Trinamool goons can do whatever they want,” he said.

Mr. Gandhi said that in its previous manifesto, the Trinamool Congress government had promised about five lakh jobs but about 84 lakh youth had applied for unemployment honorarium this year.

The Congress leader targeted both the BJP and the Trinamool Congress over corruption. “If (Narendra) Modi is the most corrupt Prime Minister in the country, then the Trinamool has broken all records of corruption in Bengal,” Mr. Gandhi said, referring to the Saradha and Rose Valley scams.

Crimes against women

Alleging a rise in crimes against women and political violence, he said, “A total dictatorship is going on in Bengal.”

He accused the BJP and the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh of “destroying the Constitution with their “hate-filled thinking”. Accusing the BJP of being “involved in vote theft”, he termed the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls an “unconstitutional” exercise.

The Congress has decided to go solo and fielded candidates for all 294 Assembly seats, breaking up a nearly decade-long electoral understanding with the Left Front in the State.

During the rallies, the Congress leader reiterated the party’s promises in its manifesto, including providing ₹10 lakh health insurance for every citizen, ₹15,000 to each farmer, 200 units of free electricity for agricultural purposes and ₹2,000 to every woman.

Mr. Gandhi criticised the Prime Minister over the India-U.S. trade deal. “It will lead to closure of small and mid-size industries, and cause job loss in India... Control over Modi is in the hands of U.S. President Donald Trump,” he said, adding the trade deal would harm workers, farmers and small traders.

IN FOCUS

T. Ramakrishnan
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu has generally been showcased as an egalitarian State that has been able to transcend the barrier of caste, thanks to the Dravidian movement. But, when it comes to elections, the factor of caste is extremely important, which the two Dravidian forces can ill-afford to ignore.

According to the findings of a couple of studies on the caste profiles of candidates put up by the formations led by the DMK and the AIADMK, three communities – Vanniyakula Kshatriya (Vanniyar), Mukkulathor (Thevars) and Kongu Vellalar (Gounders) – take the lion’s share. Of the 188 general constituencies, about 45% of the DMK-led coalition’s candidates and around 55% of the AIADMK-led front’s candidates belong to these groups, up from 38% and 47% respectively five years ago.

This time, the DMK and its allies have nominated 29 candidates each from the Vanniyar and the Kongu Vellalar communities and 27 Mukkulathors, whereas the figures for the



The AIADMK’s Edappadi K. Palaniswami and the DMK’s O. Panneerselvam campaigning for the election. M. MOORTHY & L. BALACHANDAR

AIADMK-led alliance are 43, 28 and 32, respectively.

Element of irony

As far as the AIADMK is concerned, an element of irony is being felt this time, as it was considered not long ago a “party of Mukkulathors” because of the proximity of V.K. Sasikala to former Chief Minister Jayalalithaa, who was the party’s general secretary during 1988-2016. But, in the current election, Ms. Sasikala, now heading the All India Puratchi Thalavar Makkal Munnetra Kazhagam (AIPTMMK), and the Dravidian major’s former coordinator O. Panneerselvam, now in the

DMK – both Mukkulathors – are vigorously campaigning against the AIADMK’s general secretary, Edappadi K. Palaniswami, a Kongu Vellalar.

As for the Scheduled Castes, the two fronts have fielded a few candidates in general seats in addition to 44 meant for the community.

Surprisingly, Brahmins, widely perceived in the State as a liability in electoral politics, are being courted by the Naam Tamilar Katchi (NTK) and the Tamilaga Vetttri Kazhagam (TVK), which have fielded six and two candidates, respectively. The AIADMK, for the first time since 1991,

has not fielded any Brahmin candidate, while the DMK, as in the past, has chosen not to put up anyone from the community, even though it admitted the AIADMK’s former MP V. Maitreyan into its fold about eight months ago.

Idea reinforced

Pointing out that caste remains integral to the State elections, R. Kannan, a former UN diplomat and now a political writer, acknowledges that “we have not been able to transcend caste”. The emphasis on social justice has ironically reinforced the idea of caste. Electoral politics is

the route to real power. Feudalism and caste were intertwined in the Congress era (up to 1967). In the case of the DMK, the caste pyramid has been preserved except that the lower tier of various castes could move forward, as opposed to the rich and the landed in the Congress era. The AIADMK’s founder, M.G. Ramachandran, democratised the Tamil polity even further. But, caste remains central to any equation, though there have been exceptions, Dr. Kannan explains.

Broadly echoing the political writer’s stand on social justice, K.A. Manikumar, Professor of history at

Manonmaniam Sundaranar University in Tirunelveli, says affirmative action has rendered the distribution of social justice disproportionately. Certain “upper-caste non-Brahmins” were the beneficiaries in the first instance. Castes such as the Gounders, Mukkulathors and Vanniyars have “used their caste solidarity” to get into the legislature and other institutions.

As they are well-entrenched, those caste groups, which have been feeling sidelined, “deploy the instrument of caste” to mobilise their people. Generally, political parties, barring the Left, make it a point to interact with caste leaders at all levels during elections to seek their support, Professor Manikumar said, adding that politicians consider caste important for their survival.

G. Palanithurai, a veteran academic who headed the Chair for Panchayat Raj Studies in the Department of Political Science and Development Administration of the Gandhigram Rural Institute, finds fault with the political parties, which are wedded to the age-old caste calculations. “The people in general have moved on, and only the parties have not caught up with them,” he says.

‘West Bengal election must be postponed till all legitimate voters are on the rolls’

If the rolls are not complete before being frozen, then what is the legitimacy of the election itself, asks five-time Congress MP and party’s Baharampur candidate; a sinister design is being played in name of construction of temples, mosques, he says

INTERVIEW

Adhir Ranjan Chowdhury

Shrabana Chatterjee
Shiv Sahay Singh



SHRABANA CHATTERJEE

Five-time Congress MP and former leader of the party in the Lok Sabha Adhir Ranjan Chowdhury, who is contesting the West Bengal Assembly election from Baharampur constituency, says there is no difference between the politics of Mamata Banerjee and Narendra Modi. He says the special intensive revision is an unprecedented attack on the electorate of West Bengal. Edited excerpts:

You have been saying that the election should be postponed until all legitimate voters are included on the final voter list. Since the campaign for election has started, do you still feel the same?

Absolutely, this election should be stopped because not a single legitimate voter should be left out. What

is the responsibility of the Election Commission? It is incumbent on the EC to enrol every voter. If the electoral rolls are not complete before being frozen, then what is the legitimacy of the election itself? Because free and fair election is directly dependent on a free and fair electoral roll.

Before the start of the SIR, the Chief Election Commissioner had said that not a single legitimate voter will be left out, but now he has changed his stance. What do you think?

Yes, the EC is not sticking to its own commitment. Every day, sermons are being given by Mamata Banerjee. She had promised the people of West Bengal

that she will be the last person to be included in the electoral rolls. But when lakhs of people are being left out, what is the rationale of Ms. Banerjee to seek a re-election? She should oppose this election where legitimate voters are being deprived.

Do you think we should be coming out of the religious polarisation and the mandir/masjid politics which has been prevailing in West Bengal?

A sinister design is being played in the name of construction of temples and mosques. I am not against construction of religious structures, but the issue is the way it is being done to polarise the people. Have

you ever seen a foundation stone of a mosque being laid out before the construction? It is clear that some sort of political dividend is expected out of such activities.

We are trying to tell the people that the construction of temples and mosques will not solve their problems. It is just to hide the government’s own inefficiencies and incompetencies. The issues related to our daily lives are being sidelined and certain forces are taking advantage of it.

How do you think that the BJP and Trinamool are gaining out of politics of polarisation?

There is no difference in the political character of Mamata and Modi. The manner in which the CBI and other agencies target anti-Modi forces in Delhi, in a similar manner those who oppose Mamata in West Bengal are targeted by her State machinery.

You have been a strong supporter of the Left-Congress alliance. Wouldn’t it have been better had the two parties joined hands

this election?

During my tenure as West Bengal Congress president I had supported this alliance sincerely. But politics is a dynamic phenomenon. This time, Congress thought it was prudent to fight the election alone on the capability of the party.

You are a five-time MP. Now you are contesting the Assembly election from Baharampur, where you stay. You have faced protests during your campaign. How do you see this development?

I am being treated by Mamata Banerjee as her sworn enemy. She does not make a differentiation between an enemy and an adversary. Politically I am her adversary, but I am not her enemy. But in West Bengal when democratic spaces are being squeezed out and autocracy is being enforced upon people then any campaigning by the Opposition is being seen as an act by the enemy. All kinds of nefarious activities are hatched to defeat me. Their single objective is to defeat me.

Modi asks BJP workers to list ‘crimes’ of Trinamool

The Hindu Bureau
KOLKATA

In an interaction with BJP workers on Tuesday, Prime Minister Narendra Modi asked them to make a list of “crimes” and “failures” of the Trinamool Congress government in West Bengal.

Mr. Modi held a virtual meeting, “*Mera sabse mazboot* (My booth is the strongest)”, with the *karyakartas* of West Bengal BJP and discussed poll preparedness.

“First, make a list of the crimes committed in your area. Tell the people that these happen because the goons have the blessings of big Trinamool leaders,” Mr. Modi said. He urged the BJP workers to remind the people of Bengal about the list of “failures and crimes” of the ruling party.

The Prime Minister said that there was a sense of fear and unease across the State. Youth remained troubled about lack of jobs, potato farmers were scared of Trinamool’s “syndicates”, and people were in constant fear because of rapes, murders, riots, and political violence in West Bengal. He instructed the BJP workers to reach out to women and address their concerns.

INBRIEF



PM inaugurates six-lane Delhi-Dehradun expressway

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Tuesday inaugurated a six-lane Delhi-Dehradun expressway, a ₹12,000-crore project that is set to reduce travel time between the two cities from five-six hours to about 2-2.5 hours. The 213-km access-controlled corridor now open for use is expected to significantly improve regional connectivity, linking key towns in Uttar Pradesh, before reaching Dehradun. It will also integrate with major national corridors, including the Delhi-Mumbai, Delhi-Katra, and Delhi-Meerut expressways.

ED secures 10-day remand of I-PAC director Vinesh Chandel

The Enforcement Directorate has secured a 10-day remand of I-PAC director Vinesh Kumar Chandel in connection with an alleged money-laundering case. The ED probe is based on an FIR registered by the Delhi police. The investigation has allegedly unearthed multiple instances of financial irregularities and various modes of money laundering, including receipt of accounted and unaccounted funds, issuance of bogus bills and invoices, as well as movement of cash through ‘hawala’ channels with international links. The agency has so far detected ₹50 crore allegedly linked to crime.

After Noida protests, U.P. announces hike in wages

Mayank Kumar
NOIDA

The Uttar Pradesh government on Tuesday announced an interim hike in minimum wages for unskilled, semi-skilled, and skilled workers, a day after workers organised a massive protest in Noida, in the Gautam Buddha Nagar district, which turned violent. The State government, however, has rejected claims that the minimum pay has been raised to ₹20,000 per month and stated that employers are not following this direction.

The State government announced that it has engaged with all relevant stakeholders and has opted to implement a temporary increase in the minimum wage. As part of this temporary measure, the State government has increased the minimum wage for unskilled workers throughout the State by as much as 21%, effective from April 1.

Two students dead after taking drugs at concert in Mumbai, say police

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

Two college students, a man and a woman, both 24, died after consuming drugs at a music concert in Mumbai on Saturday night, the police said. Another student remains under intensive care in a hospital.

The police have arrested five people: two fellow students and three individuals linked to organising the concert.

A group of friends from a college were among the 4,000-strong crowd at the concert at the Nesco Exhibition Centre in Goregaon East. According to the police, three students from the group consumed drugs during the event. Soon, their health deteriorated, and they were taken to hospitals.

The man died in a private hospital in Goregaon on Sunday. Two women were

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

The Union government has formulated a new deportation policy under which all States have been asked to set up a special task force in each district to ‘detect, identify and deport/send back illegal migrants from Bangladesh and Myanmar’, and provide a monthly status report on foreigners who are missing or overstaying their visas.

The States have been asked to operationalise “holding centres/camps” with a 10-foot-high boundary ringed with barbed wire, to restrict the movement of such undocumented migrants till they are deported or “sent back” to Bangladesh or Myanmar, says the policy framed by the Union Home Ministry.

An upper limit of 90 days has been fixed to verify the antecedents of suspected Bangladeshi or Myanmarese nationals, if they claim to be a resident of another State. Private buildings could also be hired to run as holding centres, if government land was not available, the

Ministry said. The States have been asked to upload documents, including Aadhaar, driving licence, and PAN cards, obtained by illegal migrants on a portal, so that they could be cancelled, and the person “blacklisted” in government records.

Many sent back

After the regime change in Bangladesh in August 2024, the police across the country were asked by the Ministry to detect Bangladeshis who had illegally entered the country and were living here on forged documents. The drive assumed momentum after the Pahalgam terror attack on April 22, 2025, and Operation Sindoor on May 7, 2025. In some cases, undocumented Bangladeshis were flown on Indian Air Force (IAF) planes and sent to Bangladesh via the land border. At least seven West Bengal residents who were pushed to Bangladesh by the Border Security Force (BSF) on suspicion of being Bangladeshis were brought back to India due to the intervention of the West Bengal government.

A major part of the poli-



Last year, the Gujarat Police had conducted an overnight operation in Ahmedabad to identify undocumented migrants. FILE PHOTO

cy that was shared with the States in February, a copy of which has been seen by *The Hindu*, reiterates and consolidates the existing guidelines with a separate chapter dedicated to “illegally staying Bangladeshis/Myanmar nationals in the country”. The guidelines on “holding centres” will be applicable to other foreigners awaiting deportation, and those declared foreigners by Foreigners’ Tribunals (FTs). FTs are unique to Assam.

States have been directed to immediately initiate nationality verification of arrested foreigners so that travel documents are rea-

ched upon the completion of judicial proceedings, enabling expeditious deportation. “After deportation, proposals for blacklisting of such foreign nationals to prevent their future entry into India may be sent to the Bureau of Immigration,” the Ministry said. “Foreigners Identification Portal (FIP)” has been launched to capture the biometric and demographic details of “illegal foreigners”, it said.

“Bangladeshis/Myanmar nationals who are intercepted at India’s land or maritime border, shall immediately be sent back by the designated Border

Guarding Forces/ Coast Guard, then and there, after capturing their biometrics and demographic details on the FIP,” the Ministry said.

In case of people who inadvertently cross the border, the designated border guarding force shall take them into custody and interrogate them, and “if found innocent, they may be handed over to the border guarding force of Bangladesh or Myanmar”, or to the police, if found guilty, before capturing the biometrics, the Ministry said.

The holding centre should have separate enclosures for men and women, and should be equipped with all amenities, including an LPG connection in the kitchen, fire safety system, strict access control measures and adequate security personnel for round-the-clock security, it said.

“There should be sufficient open space within the compound for foreigners whose movements are restricted to move around in a secure environment,” the Ministry added, and it should be ensured that

members of the same family were not separated, and all family members were housed in the same holding centre/camp.

“The persons housed in the holding centres/camps should be permitted to meet/communicate with the family members and no restrictions shall be imposed on this account. Such persons may be allowed to keep basic mobile phones to communicate with their family members and the Embassy/High Commission concerned. Facility of landline phone may also be provided in the Holding Centre/Camp for use of inmates,” the MHA said.

The MHA said that holding centres should not be run from jails, and States may also consider the engagement of language interpreters, mobile medical dispensaries, and 24×7 ambulances, and special attention may be given to women/nursing mothers, transgenders, children, etc. It also suggested crèche facilities for children, and educational facilities for child inmates, by admitting them in local schools nearby.

Bihar govt. to accelerate growth under ‘7 Nishchay-3’ plan, says Nitish

Amarnath Tewary
PATNA

Janata Dal (United) president Nitish Kumar on Tuesday said that Bihar would make significant advancements under the 7 Nishchay-3 plan for the State.

Mr. Kumar, who resigned as Chief Minister of the State, wrote in a social media post, “You know that on November 24, 2005, the NDA government was formed in the State for the first time... Work has been done for everyone, every sector... for women and youth.”

“For the next five years, that is, from 2025 to 2030, the formation of 7 Nishchay-3 (seven resolves) has been done. This will lead to even more work, as a result of which Bihar will advance significantly,” he stated.

The 7 Nishchay-3 Programme is Bihar’s third multi-year development agenda, covering the period 2025-2030.

On Tuesday, Mr. Nitish



Nitish Kumar with Bihar Governor Syed Ata Hasnain after tendering his resignation as Chief Minister in Patna on Tuesday. PTI

reached the Raj Bhavan along with senior NDA leaders at 3 p.m. and submitted his resignation to the Governor. He came out in five minutes accompanied by JD(U) leader Vijay Kumar Choudhary and BJP leader Samrat Choudhary, and headed for the CM’s official residence at 1 Anne Marg.

About an hour later, Mr. Samrat Choudhary was unanimously elected the leader of the BJP Legislature Party at a meeting

held at the party’s State headquarters in Patna. His name was proposed by fellow Deputy CM Vijay Kumar Sinha, and seconded by other party leaders, including Mangal Pandey, Raghvendra Pratap Singh, Renu Devi, and Dilip Jaiswal, and then officially announced by central observer Shivraj Singh Chouhan.

In a social media post, Mr. Choudhary expressed his “heartfelt gratitude” to the party’s central leadership of the BJP for “repos-

ing their trust in him”.

“This is not merely a position for me but a sacred opportunity to serve the people of Bihar, to fulfil their trust and dreams,” he said.

“I will remain continuously committed to taking Bihar to new heights of development, good governance and prosperity. Your affection, blessings and cooperation are my greatest strength,” he added.

He was then elected the leader of the NDA legislature party at a meeting held at the Central Hall of the State legislature. Mr. Kumar garlanded him and led the applause to welcome his successor, even as Mr. Choudhary touched Mr. Kumar’s feet to seek his blessings.

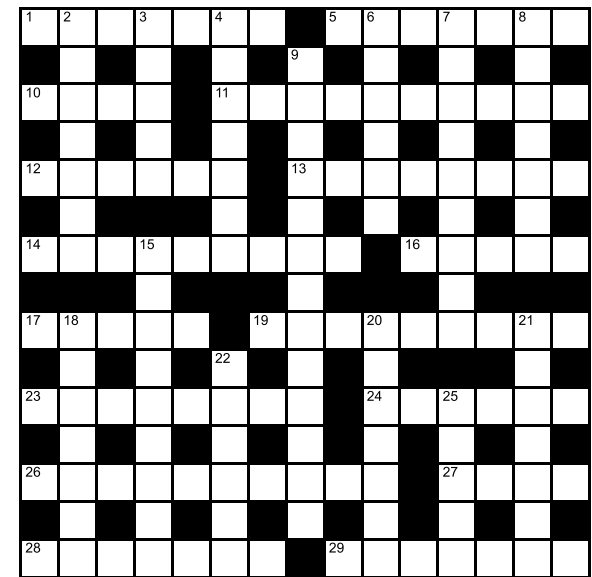
As Mr. Choudhary and a group of NDA leaders headed to the Raj Bhavan to stake claim to form the new government, posters adorned the streets of Patna welcoming him as the new Chief Minister.

THE CROSSWORD+ 14768

(set by Avtaar)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at <https://thehindu.com/crosswords>

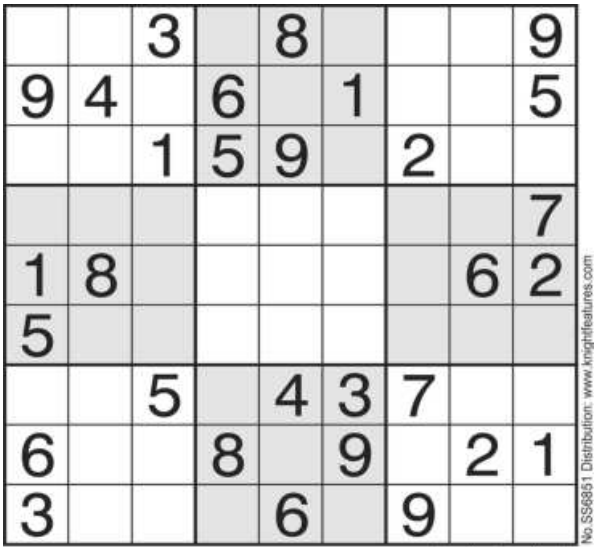
SCAN TO PLAY



- Across**
- Party in bar turned extremely raunchy (7)
 - Put on stage for Mussolini, perhaps (7)
 - Small water inlet outside entrance to bathroom (4)
 - Mobile mass seen briefly on river around source of oil (6,4)
 - Caution by English guards to walk softly (6)
 - Shout about bone across centerpiece in grill used in the kitchen (8)

- Stir as tension breaks (9)
 - Fiend in English county heartlessly stealing money (5)
 - Very likely committed Bob’s heading to border (5)
 - Snare in celebration springing back behind bust (5,4)
 - Rum from Antigua - rare medicine - on the counter (8)
 - Overcome by corrosion, banks of Euphrates turned reddish brown (6)
 - Seals cracks in intricately woven material (10)
 - Helps millions fleeing terrible disease (4)
 - Messenger Avtaar’s apprehending scoundrel with hesitation (7)
 - Dream of fellow worker shattered, say (7)
- Down**
- Devious general cancelling PR (7)
 - Country broadcast logotype giving away 50 rings (5)
 - Honour vision about becoming leader (7)
 - Back member after German leaves fold (6)
 - Purge toxic insecticide with fluorine, after dropping ice (9)
 - Man in church given port for good health (7)
 - My coach’s positive when I have cut off straying of the mind and body (13)
 - US city backs probing radical faceless agencies, having identical traits (9)
 - Lover at eatery having had too much (7)
 - Coffee-maker is included in 22, say (7)
 - Section of Mossad negated flipping schedules (7)
 - Stock exchange? (6)
 - Lean factory replacing leader with second (5)

SUDOKU



Solution to previous puzzle

Solution to yesterday’s Sudoku

FAITH

Decoding the new year

The Tamil New Year is ushered in with the reading and hearing of the *panchangam* (almanac). What was once a daily ritual has now become an annual aspect, factored in by many people alongside temple visits, seeking the blessings of gurus and elders. It is important to listen to the reading of the almanac by spiritual scholars in temples on Tamil New Year’s day, said B. Damodara Deekshithar. The almanac gives a sneak peek into what lies ahead.

Our ancestors calculated time based on the movement of the stars and the planets, preparing the blueprint for the almanac. Five aspects are taken into consideration in preparing the *panchangam*. These are *tithi* (the movement of the moon vis-à-vis the sun and the intervening days between them), *vaaram* (seven days), the stars (numbering 27), *yogam* and *karanam* (12 hours in a day). Each of these aspects hold a clue to how the day would be. For example, during siddha yogam and amrita yogam on a given day, one can undertake auspicious activities but avoid them during the inauspicious marana yogam. By reading the almanac daily, one can have overcome ill health and achieve one’s targets. At a wider level, the almanac also gives information on various aspects that impact one’s daily life in a social context. Weather forecast, impending famine or war are all mentioned under various positions of the planets and the stars during various times of the year.

The new Tamil year, named Parabhava, augurs well for cows: they will flourish and the production of dairy products will be robust; due to good rainfall, farmers will reap good harvest. While those in governance will perform well, disruptions will also be a part of political life.

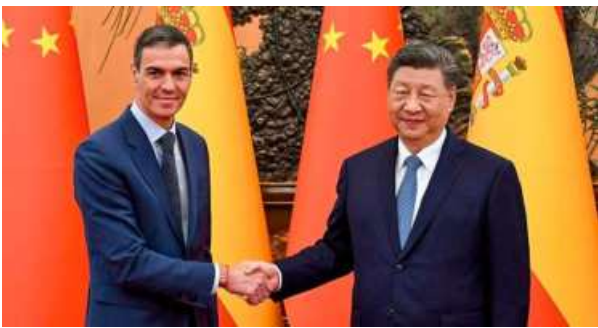
DHAKA
About 250 feared missing after boat capsizes in Andaman Sea: UN



FILE PHOTO

About 250 people, including children, were feared missing after a boat carrying Rohingya refugees and Bangladeshi nationals capsized in the Andaman Sea, the United Nations said on Tuesday. “The trawler, which departed from Teknaf in Bangladesh and was on its way to Malaysia, reportedly sank due to heavy winds.” AFP

BEIJING
Xi calls for closer economic ties with Spain in face of global ‘chaos’



AFP

China’s President Xi Jinping warned against a return to the “law of the jungle” in international relations and called for closer economic ties with Spain as he met Prime Minister Pedro Sanchez on Tuesday, according to Chinese state media. The meeting in Beijing came on the second day of Sanchez’s visit to China. AFP

WASHINGTON
U.S. to allow waiver on Iran oil to expire, say administration sources



AP

The Trump administration will allow a 30-day waiver of sanctions on Iranian oil at sea to expire later this week, two administration officials said on Tuesday. The move signals that “Treasury is going full force on Economic Fury,” on Iran, an apparent reference to Operation Epic Fury, the U.S.-led military campaign. REUTERS

ROME
Italy pauses defence cooperation deal with Israel, says PM Meloni



AP

Italy has decided to suspend the automatic renewal of a defence cooperation deal with Israel, Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni said on Tuesday, citing the conflicts in West Asia. Ms. Meloni’s right-wing government has been one of Israel’s closest allies in Europe, but in recent weeks it has criticised Israeli attacks on Lebanon. REUTERS

Efforts under way for second set of U.S.-Iran talks as fragile truce holds

First talks were part of an ongoing diplomatic process rather than a one-off effort, say Pak. officials; second round is likely to be held this week; *Rich Starry*, a tanker owned by a Chinese company and sanctioned by U.S., crosses the Strait of Hormuz

Associated Press
ISLAMABAD

The standoff between the United States and Iran deepened on Tuesday as the U.S. declared it had blockaded Iran’s ports, Tehran threatened to strike targets across the region, and Pakistan said it was racing to bring the sides together for more talks.

Though last week’s ceasefire appeared to hold, the showdown over the Strait of Hormuz risked reigniting hostilities and deepening the regional war’s economic fallout.

Talks aimed at permanently ending the conflict – which began February 28 with U.S. and Israeli strikes on Iran – failed to



Hopeful sequel: A security guard stands atop the Serena Hotel, the venue where Iran and U.S. held peace talks earlier in Islamabad. AFP

produce an agreement last weekend, though Pakistan has proposed hosting a second round in the coming days.

Two Pakistani officials said the first talks were part of an ongoing diplomatic process rather than a one-off effort.

Two U.S. officials said on Monday that discussions were still under way about a new round of talks. A diplomat from one of the mediating countries said Tehran and Washington had agreed to it.

The talks could happen on Thursday, according to

the U.S. officials. The location, timing and composition of the delegations had not been decided, although Islamabad and Geneva are being considered as host cities.

The blockade is intended to pressure Iran, which has exported millions of barrels of oil, mostly to Asia, since the war began. The blockade of Iranian ports involves more than 10,000 military personnel, more than a dozen warships and dozens of aircraft, U.S. Central Command said.

At least three ships sailing from Iranian ports crossed the Hormuz Strait despite the blockade, but some vessels taking the route later turned back, maritime tracking data indicated. They were among

at least seven Iran-linked vessels that passed through the strait after the blockade came into effect, according to maritime data provider Kpler.

A Chinese tanker, the *Rich Starry*, also crossed the strait overnight from Monday to Tuesday via the Iranian-approved vetting route south of Larak Island. Kpler said that vessel was carrying 31,500 tonnes of methanol and was bound for Sohar in Oman, according to data from its transponder. It turned around while in the Gulf of Oman on Tuesday and headed back up towards the strait.

The *Rich Starry* is listed by the United States’ Office of Foreign Assets Control as being sanctioned for ties to Iran.

China calls U.S. blockade of Iran ports ‘dangerous’

Agence France-Presse
BEIJING

China accused the United States on Tuesday of “dangerous and irresponsible” behaviour over its blockade of Iranian ports, with President Xi Jinping vowing Beijing would play a “constructive role” in promoting peace in the West Asia.

U.S. President Donald Trump has threatened to sink ships entering or leaving Iranian ports and coastal areas in the Gulf after peace talks between Washington and Tehran failed over the weekend.

The blockade came into force at 1400 GMT on Monday, despite the United States and Iran agreeing to a fragile two-week ceasefire days earlier.

“The U.S. increased military deployments and took a targeted blockade action, which will only exacerbate tensions and un-



Guo Jiakun

dermine the already fragile ceasefire agreement and further jeopardise safety of passage through the Strait [of Hormuz],” Chinese Foreign Ministry spokesperson Guo Jiakun told a news conference. “This is dangerous and irresponsible behaviour,” he added.

Iran has effectively closed the vital Strait of Hormuz, allowing only vessels serving countries it deems friendly – such as China – to cross.

Mr. Trump’s blockade, analysts say, aims to starve Iran of funds and pressure

Beijing, the biggest buyer of Iranian oil, to push Tehran to open the strait, through which one-fifth of global oil transits in peacetime.

Tehran’s ambassador to the United Nations called Mr. Trump’s blockade a “grave violation” of Iran’s sovereignty.

Speaking publicly about the war for the first time, Mr. Xi echoed those warnings, calling for the national sovereignty of countries in the West Asia and the Gulf to be “respected”.

China also took a firm stance on Tuesday against Mr. Trump’s threats to impose new tariffs on Chinese products entering the U.S. following reports Beijing was supplying or intends to supply weapons to Iran.

Mr. Trump had said he would hit China’s goods with a 50% tariff if it provided military assistance to Tehran.

Carney gets majority after three special election wins

Associated Press
TORONTO

Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney returns to Parliament on Tuesday with more power after he secured a majority government by sweeping three special elections.

Mr. Carney’s Liberals now have 174 of the 343 seats in the House of Commons and won’t need support from Opposition parties to pass legislation after winning three districts that became vacant after last year’s election.

Mr. Carney’s government is the first in Canada’s history to switch from a minority to a majority between national elections.

The Liberal Party could stay in power until 2029 after Monday’s results.

“Voters have placed their trust in our new government’s plan. We ac-



Mark Carney

cept that support with humility, determination and a clear understanding of what this moment demands,” Mr. Carney said in a post on social media.

Mr. Carney won Canada’s election last year, fuelled by public anger over U.S. President Donald Trump’s annexation threats, and he has vowed to reduce Canada’s reliance on the U.S.

Since then, five defections from Opposition parties, including four from the main Opposition Con-

servative party, put Mr. Carney’s Liberals on the cusp of the majority.

One of those defectors referenced Mr. Carney’s speech at the World Economic Forum in Davos, Switzerland, as helping in his decision. In that speech, Mr. Carney condemned economic coercion by great powers against smaller countries and received widespread praise for his remarks.

Mr. Carney, the former head of the Bank of England as well as Canada’s central bank, has moved the Liberals to the centre-right since replacing Justin Trudeau as PM in 2025.

Nelson Wiseman, professor emeritus at the University of Toronto, said Mr. Trump has been a major factor in Mr. Carney’s rise to Prime Minister, but his performance on the world stage has only added to his popularity.

Gone too soon



A relative mourns over the body of three-year-old Yahya al-Malahi, who was killed in an Israeli strike, ahead of her funeral in Gaza City on Tuesday. Gaza’s civil defence agency said four persons, one of them a toddler, were killed in the northern part of the Palestinian territory. AFP

Lebanon and Israel hold direct talks in decades

Associated Press
WASHINGTON

Lebanon and Israel opened their first direct diplomatic talks in decades on Tuesday in Washington following more than a month of war between Israel and the Hezbollah militant group, with Secretary of State Marco Rubio calling it a “historic opportunity”.

Mr. Rubio said the Trump administration is “very happy” to be facilitating the discussions, while noting that “we understand we’re working against decades of history and complexities” that will not be quickly resolved.

Hezbollah opposes the direct talks and was not represented, while the Iranian-backed group appeared to step up its fire on northern Israel.

West Asia war threatens to push 2.5 mn into poverty: UNDP

Press Trust of India
UNITED NATIONS

The conflict and military escalation in West Asia threatens to push 2.5 million people in India into poverty and the country is projected to experience some loss in its human development progress, according to estimates and projections by the United Nations.

The United Nations Development Programme (UNDP), in a report titled ‘Military Escalation In The Middle East: Human Deve-

lopment Impacts Across Asia And The Pacific’ noted that the conflict is “widening human development pressures across Asia and the Pacific. Through higher fuel, freight, and input costs, the shock is diminishing household purchasing power, raising food insecurity, straining public budgets, and weakening livelihoods”.

The preliminary assessment, issued on Tuesday, estimates that globally 8.8 million people are at risk of falling into poverty and the West Asia military escala-

tion could cost Asia-Pacific up to \$299 billion.

In India, poverty is expected to rise from around 4,00,000 to 2.5 million, the report said. It added that the number of people pushed into poverty in the world as a result of the conflict rises from approximately 1.9 million to nearly 8.8 million across scenarios, with South Asia accounting for the largest share, ranging from about 1.7 million to over 8 million, reflecting both the subregion’s population size and its higher expo-

The preliminary assessment estimates that globally 8.8 mn people are at risk of falling into poverty

sure to income and price shocks. China is estimated to experience a more moderate increase in the number of people at risk of falling into poverty, from around 1,15,000 to over 6,20,000, reflecting small proportional changes applied to a very large population base.

Highlighting the estimated poverty impact of the military escalation, the report said that India’s poverty rate is estimated to rise to 24.2% post-crisis from 23.9%, pushing 24,64,698 people into poverty.

An estimated 35,40,33,698 people are projected to live in poverty in the country post-crisis as compared to 35,15,69,000 pre-crisis.

The UNDP simulation estimates the impact of the conflict on the Human Development Index (HDI) for

countries across the region. It indicates that Iran’s HDI could decline by an amount equivalent to roughly one to one and a half years of human development progress.

“India is projected to experience a loss of approximately 0.03-0.12 years of HDI progress,” it said.

The report notes that among the region’s larger importers, India meets over 90% of its oil needs through imports, sourcing more than 40% of crude imports and 90% of LPG imports from West Asia.

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OFFICE OF EXECUTIVE ENGINEER, M&H, Div.-Kota
No. 52
Date 08-04-2026

Notice Inviting Bid No. 01/2026-27

Bids for 01 (One Nos.) Work are invited from interested bidders upto 06:00 PM dated 30.04.2026 Other particulars of the bid may be visited on the procurement portal (<http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in>, <http://sppp.raj.nic.in>) of the state and M&H departmental website. The approximate value of the procurement is Rs. 500.00 Lacs.

Executive Engineer
M&H, Div.-Kota
DIPR/C/6753/2026

INBRIEF



Dominant Uttar Pradesh boys clinch sub-junior Natl. crown

Uttar Pradesh Hockey clinched the title at the 16th Hockey India sub-junior men's National championship in Rajgir (Bihar) with a 5-2 win over Hockey Madhya Pradesh in the final.

The result (final): Uttar Pradesh 5 (Ketan Kushwaha 4, Nitish Yadav 13-pc, Ali Shahrukh 28, Rajbhar Prahlad 35, Chauhan Raghvendra Singh 40) bt Hockey Madhya Pradesh 2 (Gazee Khan 8, Ayush Singh Lodhi 43).

Russia blanks Young Tigresses in under-17 women's friendly

The India under-17 women's team suffered a 0-3 defeat against host Russia in the second of three friendly matches in Sochi on Tuesday.

The result: Russia 3 (Sofia Syatnaya 18, Valeria Menyailova 49, 52) bt India 0.



Samson and Kerr win ICC Player-of-the-Month awards

Sanju Samson was on Tuesday named ICC Men's Player-of-the-Month for March, capping a stellar run that saw him play a defining role in India's victorious T20 World Cup campaign. Kiwi captain Amelia Kerr won the women's honour.



Vishesh takes first day's honours at Boulders Classic

The 19-year-old Vishesh Sharma of Hyderabad fired a seven-under 65 to take a one-shot lead in the opening round of the inaugural ₹1 crore Boulders Classic in Hyderabad on Tuesday. Vishesh's score, a new course record, featured an eagle on the par-5 14th, six birdies, and a lone bogey. Shubhankar Sharma carded a six-under 66 to be second along with Vinay Kumar Yadav.

AROUND THE CITY

Thrilling win for Sri Vaishnavi CC
Sri Vaishnavi CC registered an exciting three-wicket win over Thiruvallur CC in a II-A match of Thiruvallur DCA league recently.
The scores:
II-A: Thiruvallur CC 146/4 in 30 overs (K. Sadagopan 47, K. Bharath Kumar 27) lost to Sri Vaishnavi CC 147/7 in 27.5 overs (B. Vishal 57 n.o., R. Vijay 42 n.o., D. Easwar 4/21).
II-B: Aththis CC 192/8 in 30 overs (S. Sachin 48, K. Nirmal Kumar 31, S. Sathyananth 26) bt Classic 112/8 in 30 overs (J. Nilesh 29, R. Adhithya 3/8, L. Ananthan Roopan 3/30).
III-B: Pattabiram CA 254/9 in 30 overs (D. Ganesh Vardhan 43, S. Vikram 25, L. Karthikeyan 53, K. Raja Pratap 35, G. Praveen Kumar 4/59) bt Lucas TVS S&RC 175 in 25.1 overs (S. Karthik 25, M. Vinith Kumar 4/32, D. Ganesh Vardhan 3/21).

IV-B: United CC 159/9 in 30 overs (A. Murali 41, E. Surender 46, R. Abhinav 4/27, K. Sanjay Krishna 3/24) bt SS CA 120/8 in 30 overs (R. Raghul 33, K. Srinivash 25 n.o., P. Dharshan Srinivas 4/23).
SRF RC 159 in 29.5 overs (D. Jagadeesh 25, John Stephen Francies 25, A. Daniel 30, N. Kumar 29, S. Sridharan 3/34, V. Mohan 3/18) lost to Jaya Education Group RC 162/7 in 27.5 overs (V. Dinesh Kumar 33, V. Hari Prasath 25, V. Poovendhan 32, K. Saravanan 3/26).

ENGAGEMENTS

Cricket: TNCA league, I div., Singam Puli vs. Nelson SC (SSN), Jolly Rovers vs. Vijay CC (IITM-Chemplast), MRC-A vs. Young Stars (SRMC, turf), Grand Slam vs. Jupiter (Gurunanak), SKM vs. Sea Hawks (Tagore College), Globe Trotters vs. Alwarper (MRF-Pach), first day, 9.30 a.m.

LIVE TELECAST

ISL: Sony Sports Ten 2 & FanCode, 7.30 p.m.
IPL: Star Sports 1 & JioHotstar, 7.30 p.m.
Champions League: Sony Sports Ten 1, 2, 3 & LIV, 12.30 a.m. (Thursday).

Vishvanath determined to make CWG, Asiad squads

The 21-year-old, who won the 50kg title at the Asian championships, is working towards gaining weight and qualifying for the 55kg category; the Chennai lad's aim is to win gold at the LA Games

BOXING

Y.B. Sarangi
KOLKATA

Vishvanath Suresh, the newly-crowned Asian boxing champion in 50kg at Ulaanbaatar, is ready to go up to 55kg in order to make it to the Indian teams for the Commonwealth and the Asian Games.

A World youth champion in 2022 and an Asian under-22 champion in 2024, Vishvanath, a product of the Army Sports Institute (ASI), Pune, waited for his time to compete at the elite level.

Breaking the drought

"I was No. 2 in my weight in the Services team and the No.1 boxer went to the National championships. After regular training, I did some extra work, which helped me. I got a chance and won the National title (in January last).

The Asian championships was my first major event. In the past few years, India didn't have an Asian champion (in men's boxing). Now I've become one," Vishvanath told *The Hindu*.



Satisfying verdict: Vishvanath says the win over World champion Tashkenbay at the Asians gave him a lot of confidence. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

"My one-sided quarter-final win over World champion Sanzhar Tashkenbay was satisfying. The Kazakh fell off a punch in the last round. No Indian had beaten him after Amit Panghal (in the 2024 Strandja tournament). That gave me a lot of confidence."

The 21-year-old is delighted to have made his boxer father M. Suresh, who bagged junior medals in the Nationals in the mid-1990s before hanging

up his gloves to support his family, super proud.

Now the Chennai boy faces the challenge of going up to an Olympic weight, 55kg, for the Commonwealth Games and the Asian Games.

"Life is incomplete without challenges. My first target is assessment (to get selected). My body weight stays around 54kg. It will be advantageous as I can eat a bit and box. All eyes will be on me. But my hard

work will keep me ahead. I need to increase my strength for 55kg."

Vishvanath's ultimate aim is to shine at the Los Angeles Olympic Games.

"I want to win a gold in the Olympics, not just any medal. Vijender Singh's bronze in 2008 inspires me, but it's a shame that we've not won an Olympics medal (in men's boxing) since then. I want to change Indians' mindset," said Vishvanath.

A Leeds shock for Carrick's Manchester United

EURO LEAGUES

Agencies
MANCHESTER

Leeds United's Noah Okafor scored twice as his side grabbed a morale-boosting 2-1 Premier League away win over bitter rival Manchester United, which had Lisandro Martinez sent off in the 56th minute for pulling the hair of Dominic Calvert-Lewin.

Manchester United remains third in the table on 55 points, ahead of Aston Villa on goal difference, while 15th-placed Leeds put some more daylight between itself and the teams battling relegation by moving up to 36 points, six ahead of Tottenham Hotspur in 18th.

Meanwhile, United boss Michael Carrick blasted referee Paul Tierney for sending off Martinez.

"The boys stayed positive and fought to get something out of it after another shocking decision to send off Lisandro," Carrick said.

"Two games in a row we've had decisions like



Timely victory: Okafor ensured Leeds got some breathing space in the relegation battle. REUTERS

that go against us, but this one was one of the worst I've seen.

I don't even know what it looks like. It's not a pull, it's not a tug, it's not aggressive. He touches it and he gets sent off. Worst of all, he gets sent to overturn it, a clear and obvious error. Shocking."

Fiorentina edges Lazio
In the Serie A, Fiorentina beat Lazio 1-0 and moved eight points clear of the relegation zone.

Fiorentina's season-best five-game unbeaten run lifted Paolo Vanoli's men above Cagliari into 15th place.

Robin Gosens got the only goal in the 28th minute when he headed home a cross from Jack Harrison, the winger on loan from Leeds United.

With goalkeeper David de Gea in fine form, Fiorentina recorded a third clean sheet in a row in all competitions. Lazio, which lost for the first time since March 1, remained in ninth place.

The results:
Premier League: Manchester United 1 (Casemiro 69) lost to Leeds 2 (Okafor 5, 29).
LaLiga: Levante 1 (Esp1 83) bt Getafe 0.
Serie A: Fiorentina 1 (Gosens 28) bt Lazio 0.



New approach: Stokes says he and coach McCullum will work together in a slightly different way this season. FILE PHOTO

Talk of rift with McCullum a 'massive overstatement': Stokes

CRICKET

Agence France-Presse
LONDON

England cricket captain Ben Stokes has dismissed suggestions of a collapse in his relationship with coach Brendon McCullum, although he says the way they work together will "look a little bit different" this season.

Stokes and McCullum, a former New Zealand captain, have been in a close alliance since joining forces in 2022. But there appeared to be a difference in their respective approaches as England slumped to a 1-4 series Ashes loss in Australia.

Stokes opted for a more grinding, disciplined approach, as the series wore on, McCullum continued to stand by his mantra of ultra-aggressive Bazball cricket.

Both men backed each other in public and Stokes reiterated that position following media reports a post-Ashes review had revealed tensions between the duo. "Saying we weren't aligned, I think, is a massive overstatement," Stokes said in an in-house interview with the England and Wales Cricket Board published on Tuesday.

"When you're in a position of leadership along with someone else, if anyone thinks that you're always going to agree on everything, then it's just impossible."

England will be back in Test action in June, against New Zealand, before taking on Pakistan at home as well. "I'm very confident in mine and Brendon's ability to be able to work together, because we've done it for such a long period of time now, but work together in a slightly different way," Stokes said.

Bayern custodian Neuer has his task cut out against Real

CHAMPIONS LEAGUE

Agence France-Presse
MUNICH

Bayern Munich veteran Manuel Neuer is saddling up for Wednesday's Real Madrid quarterfinal second leg at home in what could be his final season before riding off into the sunset.

Though not the risk-hungry, 'sweeper keeper' of his prime, the two-time Champions League winner was outstanding in Bayern's 2-1 first-leg victory in Madrid.

Named Player-of-the-Match, Neuer made nine saves and succeeded in keeping Real's danger men Kylian Mbappe and Vinicius Junior at bay, for the most part.

Neuer, who turned 40 in March, has a contract in Munich until the end of the season.

Bayern seem willing to offer its long-time 'keeper and captain another year, but Neuer has repeatedly said he is still weighing up his future.

Despite its first-leg lead,



Safe hands: Neuer was named the Player-of-the-Match in the first leg at Bernabeu. AP

Bayern knows its opponents well – with 29 games between the sides, no European fixture has been played more – and remain wary of the Champions League specialists.

Meanwhile, Declan Rice left Arsenal manager Mikel Arteta with another injury worry on the eve of its quarterfinal second leg against Sporting Lisbon after missing the club's open training session on Tuesday.

Rice withdrew from England's recent international against Japan but returned for Arsenal's match against Sporting in Lisbon

last week. He was also the stand-in captain for the table-topping Gunners' shock defeat by Bournemouth in the Premier League last weekend.

But the 27-year-old midfielder was not involved at Arsenal's London Colney training ground on Tuesday, with Bukayo Saka, Martin Odegaard, Jurrien Timber and Riccardo Calafiori, also missing the session.

Arsenal heads into Wednesday's fixture at the Emirates with a 1-0 lead from last week's opening leg against Sporting secured by Kai Havertz's late goal.

Starc and Deepti bag Wisden Almanack's top honours

Agence France-Presse
LONDON

Indian cricketers, including Shubman Gill and Deepti Sharma dominated the Wisden Almanack 2026 awards announced on Monday. Deepti was named Leading Women's Cricketer of the Year, with Australia fast bowler Mitchell Starc receiving the men's award.

Abhishek Sharma was named Leading T20 Cricketer of the Year. Four Indians who starred in a 2-2 drawn Test series in En-



Deepti Sharma.
FILE PHOTO: EMMANUAL YOGINI

gland last year were among its Five Cricketers of the Year – Gill, Ravindra Jadeja, Rishabh Pant and Mohammed Siraj.

A tale of grit and determination — McIlroy joins the pantheon of legends

GOLF

Associated Press
AUGUSTA

Rory McIlroy went from becoming the sixth player with the career Grand Slam to only the fourth player to win the Masters two years in a row. Jack Nicklaus and Tiger Woods are the only other players to occupy both clubs.

If joining the first group wasn't difficult enough for McIlroy – 11 years of trying to get the final leg of the Grand Slam – then winning his second Masters



Victory roar: McIlroy is ecstatic after completing a special milestone. GETTY IMAGES

green jacket was a clear reminder of how hard it was to get there. It wasn't easy a year ago when he lost a Sunday lead once on the

front nine and twice on the back nine before beating Justin Rose in a play-off. It didn't look that way this time when he lost a six-

shot lead on Saturday. Scottie Scheffler was in range and had to settle for making 11 straight pars. Young had birdie putts on eight straight holes on the back nine and converted none of them.

McIlroy was a whisker away from trouble over the final hour – the wedge that barely cleared the false front on the 15th, a sporty up-and-down from off the 17th green that gave him a two-shot cushion going to the last hole, and a drive so far right McIlroy wasn't sure where it was when he walked off the tee. It ended with more joy than relief.



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If we have to become a global superpower, we need a system to produce it

Ghosal says that bringing quality coaches to India will be the first step in this direction; feels that players are currently being produced mainly due to personal drive and initiative; opines that there's enough depth in the men's ranks to defend the Asian Games gold

GETTY IMAGES

INTERVIEW

Saurav Ghosal

K. Keerthivasan

One of India's finest squash players, Saurav Ghosal, has always been someone who put 100% into whatever he did. After retiring from professional squash in June last year due to a hip issue, the first Indian male player to break into the World's top-10 has remained active on several fronts. He was recently appointed Sports Commissioner of World Premier Squash and is the Director of High-Performance Sports at Agilitas Sports, an innovation-led sportswear and athleisure solutions platform. In an interview to *The Hindu*, the 39-year-old, the owner of 11 PSA titles and also an Asian Games/Commonwealth Games medallist, and a record 13-time senior National men's champion, spoke about his role of Sports Commissioner, India's chances of defending its men's team gold at the Asian Games later this year, the future of fast-rising Anahat Singh and what it will take for Indian squash to become a powerhouse like Egypt. Excerpts:

What does the role of Sports Commissioner of World Premier Squash entail?

From the back-end, my role is all about fleshing out the league's format, what the Artificial Intelligence qualification system is going to be, liaisoning with the players to make sure that they are on board. We are very, very fortunate to have PSA and WorldSquash on board with us. It's important that they have an open mind for something like this. And they've been great partners to have helped us bring this to life, at least to launch it now. And hopefully, I'll be able to do a good job and create a concept and an event IP, which will be extremely engaging and entertaining for the entire ecosystem involved. The whole point is to democratise it as much as possible, bridge the gap between the professional and the amateur recreational kind of cohort population and bring them and consolidate them into the ecosystem. Then, create an engaging and entertaining format for people who are watching.

The League is unlike any other currently on, with Artificial Intelligence (AI) being used

Yes. To qualify for the grand final, there's going to be an AI-based qualification kind of system where basically you log on to this particular app with the intricate details being out

soon. You log on to the app, select different challenges or condition games, and just video yourself. And the AI does its thing and scores you on different things and different parameters. And you have a worldwide leaderboard. The top eight men and top eight women qualify for the grand final where they will be on court playing a novel format in the grand final with four of the top men and women in the world. The global league finals is expected to begin in August. And the qualification, we are planning to begin on April 15.

Anahat has been the poster girl of Indian squash now. You are her mentor. How do you see her progress?

My role is communicating to Anahat and translating to her all the experience that I have gathered. Being a player at the top level, you know, both on and off the court, how to manage a professional player. I think technically am just trying to add different things to her game, making her understand what she's good at, what her squash identity needs to be built around and how she can take on the best girls in the world and leveraging what she is very good at. She's got a great mentality, she's fearless. Physically, too, she's good. Of course, she can obviously get a bit stronger, which she's working on. I think she also has great composure when the ball is moving around, which is not an easy skill to have. She's developed a lot of variations now. She has kind of remnants and a semblance of what new Nour El Sherbini (eight-time women's world champion) can do to opponents. Hopefully, she can keep improving and achieve everything that she's capable of.

Anahat said bagging the gold at the forthcoming Asian Games will be a target as bagging the gold will guarantee her a spot at the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics. Can she do it?

She will definitely be there at the Asian Games. If you ask me whether she can win gold at the Games, I am not sure. I mean, look, there are a lot of good players. The two big ones, obviously, are Malaysia's S. Sivasangari and Satomi Watanabe of Japan, who are both top eight in the world, and playing some fantastic squash themselves. But having said that, you know, you go in trying to win it all. You do everything you can to to give yourself a realistic shot at doing that. Hopefully, she will do it. I think, look, even if she doesn't win it, I think she's in a good position to try and qualify on ranking points in two years' time for the 2028 Olympics. Her rate of progress is something that we are quite happy with. She's got a good head on



I think a lot more players are playing now, starting from the juniors. I think we have quantity than when I started. That is a good sign because numbers always help

her shoulders. As long as that stays and she keeps putting the work in and improving the way she does, she will get to where we think she can.

Is a place in the World's top-10 possible for Anahat?

It would be sad considering the potential she has and the seeding she has if she is not a mainstay in the top-10, if not higher, you know, over the next few years.

As far as Indian men are concerned, we have four in the top-50 and S. Velavan (WR 49) just reached there. Abhay Singh has been the best of the lot...

100% no doubt. I don't think it's ever happened before that we had four together. I think that's great. I think all the boys are strong. They all are good players in their own right. And they're all trying to kind of hustle and put the work in and get better and get higher up. And, you know, I hope that they're able to kind of keep moving forward and in the process, you know, win big things for India, starting with the Asian Games later this year. We have good depth in that sense.

It would be good to have a few more behind them as well. Abhay is a good example of someone who's maximising his potential, you know, full credit to him. He's put a lot of work into his game. He deserves to be where he's at in the rankings (WR 22) today.

What more needs to be done for India to produce top-10 players?

I think a lot more players are playing now, starting from the juniors. I think we have quantity than when I started and that is a good sign because numbers always help. We can further those numbers by taking it into schools, getting it on TV a little bit more. None of the current Indian top players train in India 365 days of the year. I never trained in India, Dipika (Pallikal) never trained, Joshna (Chinappa) didn't train 365 days of the year. I think that is something that if we are able to solve: get higher quality coaches and a system of coaches which allows you to kind of be in India, I think that will help. One is, you know, you're staying at home as a player. These players staying at home, and training with the best will be great for them and for the juniors coming up to

be able to see the best players, you know, up close and personal every single day which will create benchmarks and inspire them to kind of be better. It will perpetuate the next line of players to come through as well.

Getting the right guidance at home rather than us having to go out consistently to get that exposure. That can be done, if 2-3 top quality coaches in the world do come and settle here, it will probably cost a bit of money. We need to invest in that or, get the previous generation to be involved. I don't know who is really going to do it. But I think the crux is that: you need to get top quality people either those who have played at the top level, say World's top-10, 20, or have produced players who have played at that level. And you must have the Indian coaches working with them on a daily basis to understand and learn what their knowledge is, what their point of views are, how are they thinking in terms of producing players, and things like that. So that in 4-5 years' time, they (Indian coaches) will also have the knowledge to understand what it takes to produce a top-20 or a top-10 player.

Can we follow Egypt's system?

Currently what we have is that we have players being produced in great part due to personal drive and personal initiatives. It's not coming out of one system per se. If we have to create or become a global superpower, like Egypt, then there needs to be a system which continuously produces it. And when I say system, I don't necessarily mean that it must centralised in one place. It can be spread out, which is what Egypt is like. In Egypt, it's spread out in two cities of Cairo and Alexandria. Even in these cities, it's spread out in different clubs. But all these clubs have systems which continuously produce top junior players who then graduate to become top professional players.

Can India do well in the Asian Games where the men's team is defending the gold and can we perform well in singles (men) as well?

We are capable. We have good depth in our team. They need to work for it. And I'm sure they know that themselves. Malaysia's Yow (Ng Eain Yow) is going to be men's top seed and he's going to be the overwhelming favourite. If Qatar's Abdulla Mohd Al-Tamimi is able to recover from his injury and come back in time with some sort of

match practice and sharpness, he will be extremely dangerous as well. There are quite a few from Malaysia and Hong Kong, and I'm sure there'll be a few from Pakistan as well, who will have a shout in as well. It's a pretty level playing field in that sense.

Still, I would say that the (Indian) boys should feel confident enough and believe that they have an edge over the others, except for a fully fit Yow and Tamimi. If they are at their best, they will have an edge on paper. But I mean, there's nothing to say that they can't be beaten or anything of that sort.

In your illustrious career, you won many medals at the Asian Games and Commonwealth Games. Which one is special?

There are lots of memorable things. The first Asian Games bronze medal in Doha in 2006, which was a big turning point, not just for me, but for Indian squash in general. The 2022 Commonwealth Games singles bronze medal in Birmingham was like a culmination of my entire career.

The two Asian Games men's team gold medals in 2014 and 2022-23 is something as a kid I always wanted to have and to have got two is great. Getting to the top-10 in the world was a dream always.



R. RAGU

New cell therapy shows promise to treat frailty among elderly

Frailty is not a single disease with a single cause: it arises from the effects of chronic inflammation, muscle loss, vascular ageing, immune dysfunction, and long-term stress. Because there is no single molecular target, most medical research has focused on managing the consequences of frailty, rather than reversing the condition

Biju Dharmapalan

In many Indian homes, ageing unfolds quietly. A grandfather who once walked to the local market now pauses every few steps. A grandmother takes days to recover from a minor fall. Such changes are often dismissed as “normal ageing”. Medicine, however, increasingly recognises these signs as part of a condition called frailty, which is a state of accelerated biological ageing marked by lower endurance and slower recovery.

Frailty affects up to one in four people over the age of 50 worldwide. In India, where the population aged 60 and over is projected to rise to nearly 20% by 2050, the condition is likely widespread but rarely diagnosed. Unlike diseases such as diabetes or hypertension, frailty has no standard treatment protocol and is under-visible in policy.

A new international study suggests that this long-neglected condition may finally be biologically treatable.

Measurable gain

Researchers studying elderly individuals with frailty found that a single infusion of mesenchymal stem cells significantly improved their physical endurance. Participants aged 70 to 85 years who received the highest dose walked on average 60 m farther in a six-minute walk test nine months after treatment, which is a nearly 20% improvement over their baseline performance.

The study was part of phase IIb of the CRATUS trial and was conducted by a team that included researchers from U.S.-based biotechnology firm Longeveron. The firm’s mesenchymal stem cell product is called Lomemel-B (or laromestrocel). The study’s findings were published in the journal *Cell Stem Cell* on March 5.

For the first time, there seems to be a treatment that targets accelerated ageing itself.

Since frailty increases the risk of falls, hospitalisation, post-surgical complications, and premature death, even modest gains in endurance can be the difference between independent living and prolonged dependence.

Mesenchymal stem cells

Frailty is not a single disease with a single cause, rather it arises from the cumulative effects of chronic inflammation, muscle loss, vascular ageing, immune dysfunction, and long-term stress. Because there is no single molecular target, most medical research has focused on managing the consequences of frailty rather than reversing the condition itself.

The authors of the new study used mesenchymal stem cells, which are naturally found in bone marrow and fat tissue. These cells are biologically versatile as they can differentiate into



Representative image. A new international study suggests that this long-neglected condition may finally be biologically treatable. YUE WU/UNSPLASH

bone, cartilage or muscle and, importantly, release molecules into the bloodstream that reduce inflammation and promote tissue repair.

An added advantage is that, unlike many cell therapies, mesenchymal stem cells do not strongly activate the recipient’s immune system, thus reducing the need for immunosuppressive drugs. This is a critical safety consideration for older adults who are also frail.

The findings also confirm that while frailty has important social and psychological components, it is also a biological condition that could benefit from timely intervention. This said, how exactly laromestrocel works is unclear.

Researchers have expressed suspicion that the infused cells dampen inflammation in the tissues surrounding small blood vessels, which is a region increasingly implicated in ageing-related decline. Participants who received stem cells were found to have lower levels of a biomarker associated with inflammation in this vascular niche.

Ageing researchers are nonetheless also excited by the direction of change. Ageing-related decline is multifactorial and difficult to reverse, so seeing improvement rather than just stabilisation is encouraging. The study also reported no serious side effects. Yet the authors were careful to avoid overstating the findings, and have acknowledged that larger clinical trials and longer follow-up plans are required. Regulatory approval also remains uncertain as a phase III trial is pending and foreign regulators like India’s Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation (CDSCO) may require a

The findings confirm that while frailty has important social and psychological components, it is also a biological condition that could benefit from timely intervention

bridging trial to prove the therapy also works as intended in Indian populations.

Implications for India

India’s health system is still largely oriented towards acute illness rather than chronic ageing. Frailty is a strong predictor of hospitalisation and mortality but rarely features in clinical records or insurance claims.

India’s flagship public health insurance scheme ‘Ayushman Bharat’ focuses on hospital-based secondary and tertiary care whereas preventive geriatric assessment, functional screening, and early interventions for ageing-related vulnerabilities receive little attention. Frailty is also not recognised as a reimbursable condition.

India also has a ‘National Programme for Health Care of the Elderly’ but its reach remains limited. Geriatric clinics are scarce in district hospitals and healthcare workers seldom use frailty assessment tools. Medical education also continues to treat the consequences of ageing as inevitable.

As a result, elderly patients enter hospitals already physiologically fragile and face higher risks after surgery or illness. Which means a therapy that improves resilience, even modestly,

stands to significantly reduce the duration of hospital stays and risk of complications, and improve quality of life.

Role of ICMR

Stem-cell science in India also carries a complicated legacy. In the past, unregulated clinics have offered unproven “stem-cell cures” for a range of conditions, often exploiting vulnerable patients.

The Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR) recognised this risk and issued strict guidelines that limited the use of stem cells to approved clinical trials. This caution is essential: even the new study, while promising, does not justify immediate clinical use.

ICMR-led studies could evaluate whether stem-cell-based interventions reduce falls, improve surgical recovery or enhance the quality of life among older Indians relative to existing options, to ensure that treatments such as using laromestrocel have both medically and socially relevant outcomes.

Both India and the world are entering an era in which the path to living longer is well-understood, even if governments and policies have applied it highly unevenly. The bigger challenge today is to ensure that those who live, in whatever circumstances, are able to do so with dignity and independence.

(Biju Dharmapalan is the Dean, Academic Affairs, at Garden City University, Bengaluru and an adjunct faculty member at the National Institute of Advanced Studies, Bengaluru. bijudharmapalan@gmail.com)

THE GIST

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BIG SHOT



The Prometheus monument dating back to construction of the Chernobyl Nuclear Power Plant, amid the Russian invasion of Ukraine. An uncontrolled collapse of the internal radiation shell at the defunct nuclear power station in Ukraine could increase the risk of radioactivity release in the environment, Greenpeace warned on April 14, 2026. AFP

QUESTION CORNER

Measuring the universe

Q: What is the Hubble tension?

A: There is a major disagreement among physicists about how fast the universe is expanding. Astronomers use a value called the Hubble constant to measure it. However, the two main ways to calculate this number have produced different results.

In the first method, astronomers use the cosmic microwave background, which is the light left over from the Big Bang. Using mathematical models to project that ancient data into the present day, they have predicted a slower expansion rate of about 67 km/s per megaparsec.

For the other method, scientists study nearby objects like pulsating stars and exploding supernovae to calculate how fast they are moving away from the earth. These measurements are said to be local, and they point to an expansion rate of around 73 km/s per second per megaparsec.

The gap between these numbers is the tension. Both methods are highly precise yet their results don’t match. The discrepancy suggests that physicists’ current understanding of the universe might be incomplete.

On April 10, astronomers narrowed



The Hubble eXtreme Deep Field image taken in 2012. NASA

down the local expansion of the universe to be 73.5 km/s per megaparsec. They also confirmed that the value was correct using multiple methods. This new work doesn’t settle the debate — in fact, it goes to show how robust the data on both sides is.

Physicists are now investigating whether they have made a measurement error or if ‘new physics’, like a new property of dark energy, is driving the expansion.

For feedback and suggestions for ‘Science’, please write to science@thehindu.co.in with the subject ‘Daily page’

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Railways to install automatic systems at level crossings

1,228 The Railway Board has directed zones to expedite installation of automatic closure systems at 1,228 level crossings to ensure trains get a green signal only when gates are shut for road traffic. The move follows safety concerns after a fatal 2025 accident and targets high traffic crossings across 16 zones. PTI

India's crude oil imports from Russia surge in March

5.3 In euro billion, India's crude oil imports from Russia more than tripled to 5.3 billion euros in March 2026, driven by higher volumes and rising global prices, according to a report by the Centre for Research on Energy and Clean Air. Russian crude accounted for 91 per cent of India's total fossil fuel imports from Moscow during the month. PTI

Number of U.S., Filipino troops to join Balikatan exercises

17,000 More than 17,000 American and Filipino personnel will take part in the annual Balikatan combat exercises in the Philippines from April 20 to May 8, amid tensions in the South China Sea. The military drills will also involve forces from countries like Japan, France and Canada. PTI

Free dialysis provided for CKD patients in Haryana hospitals

1.89 in lakh. Government hospitals in Haryana has provided around 1.89 lakh free dialysis sessions to patients with chronic kidney disease in 2025-26, officials said. The State has also expanded its renal transplant programme, offering procedures and related care to patients free of cost to improve access to treatment. PTI

India's automobile wholesales hit record high in FY26

2.83 in crore. Automobile wholesales in India reached a record 2.83 crore units in FY26, marking a 10.4% year-on-year growth, according to the Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers. All segments, including passenger vehicles, two-wheelers and commercial vehicles, recorded their highest-ever annual sales. PTI

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What are the legal consequences of piracy?

The leak of Tamil movie *Jana Nayagan* before it could get a theatrical release could attract harsh penalties for the leakers if they are caught and chargesheeted, especially due to new amendments to the Cinematograph Act, 1952

EXPLAINER

Aroon Deep

The story so far:

In a blow to the movie's producers, Vijay-starrer *Jana Nayagan*, directed by H. Vinoth, was recently leaked online in its entirety in high quality while its theatrical release has been stuck in a limbo following issues with censor certificate.

The leak indicates that someone with legitimate access to the movie mishandled or intentionally spread it further. Six people have been held by authorities in connection with the leak. Film piracy through illegal downloads is rampant, but it is less common for content to become available in the first place in such high quality.

What are the laws on piracy? How well are they enforced?

The Copyright Act, 1957, deals extensively with infringement of intellectual property such as movies, TV shows, books, articles, and other creative work. Section 63 and Section 63A of the Copyright Act provide for fines of up to ₹2 lakh and three years of imprisonment. Repeat offenders can receive those same penalties again for each subsequent violation.

The Cinematograph Act, 1952, since its amendment in 2023, provides for a much larger fine: 5% of the audited gross budget of a film. While the minimum fine is decidedly smaller, judges may not look too kindly on the *Jana Nayagan* case in particular.

This is because unlike practically every other film, the Vijay starrer was leaked before it had a chance to release in theatres, denting both its theatrical value



India is seen as a 'notorious market' owing to its anemic response to piracy cases. FILE PHOTO

and home video rights valuation.

It is uncommon for film piracy cases to be investigated and pursued with vigour. India is consistently listed as a "notorious market" by U.S. authorities, for instance, for anemic responses to piracy.

However, considering the vast spectrum of voices within the film industry and political circles that has come out in support of KVN Productions, which bankrolled *Jana Nayagan*, this case may be the subject of a more serious investigation.

Judges have tended to focus more on distributors in piracy and intellectual rights cases than on individual infringers. But depending on an individual infringer's behaviour, punishments can end up hitting not just the original leaker of the film, but anyone who shares a link forward.

To boot, Tamil Nadu Police's State Cyber Crime Wing said in a press release

that those among the six arrested were sharing cloud storage links to the film.

How did this movie get leaked? How do studios protect against leaks?

Ordinarily, movies are only leaked to pirates in high quality when they appear on OTT streaming platforms. This is because once this happens, in spite of copy-resistant technologies employed by these platforms, pirates have found ways to defeat Digital Rights Management (DRM) protections on such content, and extract a video file that is close to the original stream in quality and fidelity.

As such, withholding content access from audiences at large altogether is the current gold standard. If only theatre projectionists have the movie – and that too only in an encrypted hard drive – it is much harder to copy. Invisible and barely visible watermarking enables studios to instantly identify the perpetrator if a copy

is made from a legitimate theatrical print. That makes leaking an incredibly unattractive prospect to people with access to a movie.

It is common for full videos in a film's supply chain to be visibly watermarked for the intended recipient, or to indicate a versioning. There is such a watermark for *Jana Nayagan*, but it is not yet clear if the version circulating online has enough forensic clues for investigators to zero in on a specific individual. If carelessness was involved, the harshest punishments may go to the first few people who received and distributed the film.

What happens if a movie has already been leaked?

It is incredibly challenging for a leaked film to be completely wiped from the Internet. For one, there are several sites, constantly changing their domain names to evade judicial website blocking orders. For another, private groups on messaging apps like Telegram and protocols like torrents, make the distribution of pirated content harder to stem.

However, there still remains an industry of so-called "anti-piracy" firms like AiPlex who work with filmmakers, sports broadcasters, and so on, to quickly send copyright takedown notices to social media platforms (who generally act quickly on such alerts), and torrent sites (some of whom accept and act on it).

It is also common for filmmakers to approach courts for so-called "dynamic injunctions" that allow them to constantly provide High Courts with links to non-compliant sites' URLs, after which they are blocked online. Some "John Doe" orders can be passed even before a film is leaked, in anticipation of a film becoming available on such platforms were a leak to happen.

THE GIST

It is incredibly challenging for a leaked movie to be completely wiped from the Internet

Section 63 and Section 63A of the Copyright Act, 1957, provide for fines of up to ₹2 lakh and three years of imprisonment for infringement of intellectual property

The Cinematograph Act, 1952, since its amendment in 2023, provides for a much larger fine: 5% of the audited gross budget of a film

In the *Jana Nayagan* case, the leak coming before its theatrical release has dented both its theatrical value and home video rights valuation

Balancing faith and ecology: are rivers taking the brunt?

It is observed by experts that ritual offerings accelerate microbial activity in rivers, adding to pollution loads

Saeed Pande

Story so far:

A 21-day religious ceremony at the Pataleshwar Mahadev Temple in Madhya Pradesh's Sehore district, guided by Sant Shivanand Maharaj, culminated in a controversial ritual where 11,000 litres of milk were poured into the Narmada River in what devotees described as a "sacred offering" on April 8.

Organisers aimed at purifying the river and bless Narmada Parikrama pilgrims. The incident, where a tanker was seen pouring milk, sparked a debate between religious faith and environmental concerns regarding pollution.

No official action has been taken yet by the Madhya Pradesh pollution control board or National Green Tribunal. Malnutrition in Madhya Pradesh has prompted the ₹700-crore Yashoda Milk Supply Scheme (2026-27), targeting 1.3 crore children through schools and Anganwadis.

Experts and activists argue that the 11,000 litres poured into Narmada could provide 44,000 glasses (250ml each), feeding 2,200 kids daily for 20 days or supplementing 10,000+ for a week at school programmes.

What are the impacts of ritual offerings on aquatic ecosystems?

Though culturally viewed as pure, environmental studies show dairy effluents can have biochemical oxygen demand (BOD) levels far exceeding domestic sewage, leading to rapid depletion of dissolved oxygen and ecological stress in aquatic environments.

It is observed by experts that ritual offerings further accelerate microbial activity, adding to cumulative pollution loads. This reduces dissolved oxygen, suffocating aquatic life, while nutrient enrichment can trigger algal blooms, further degrading water quality and disrupting biodiversity.

The Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB)'s 2025 assessment identified 296 polluted river stretches across 271 rivers, with water quality at over 800 locations exceeding safe limits for bathing (BOD > 3 mg/l). The CPCB also observed that the Yamuna in Delhi records BOD levels as high as 83 mg/l, nearly 27 times the safe limit, effectively rendering stretches ecologically "dead."

A monitoring committee appointed by the National Green Tribunal (NGT) in 2018 observed an "unacceptable rise" in pollution levels in the Yamuna after idol

immersion, noting sharp increases in heavy metals from paints and synthetic materials.

Empirical evidence from CPCB monitoring and peer-reviewed studies shows that events like Kumbh Mela, Chhath Puja, Durga Puja, and Ganesh Utsav raise BOD and solid waste levels. Rapid population growth has pushed river degradation to the forefront of public concern, intensifying pressures on already fragile ecosystems.

Traditions that evolved in an era of sparse populations are now practiced at a vastly larger scale, amplifying their ecological impact. In the context, it is worth asking if age-old practises need to be revisited and reimagined to ensure that devotion does not come at the cost of the very rivers it seeks to honour?

What does India's environmental laws entail?

At the apex level, the Supreme Court of India has reviewed cases involving the weakening of environmental safeguards for religious practices. Petitions rely on three legal foundations: The precautionary principle, the Water Act (Prevention and Control of Pollution), 1974, and Article 21 of the Constitution, which guarantees a clean environment.

Together, these establish that environmental protection is a binding legal obligation, even when balanced against religious freedoms. The NGT has enforced the CPCB's 2020 idol immersion guidelines, mandating artificial tanks or regulated zones for immersions. However, experts observe that no single law explicitly regulates offerings such as milk, flowers, oil, or mass bathing as a distinct category. Indian constitutional jurisprudence is clear that religious freedom under Article 25 is not absolute and can be restricted on grounds of public health. Yet, enforcement remains uneven due to political sensitivities and lack of uniform guidelines on everyday ritual practices. The NGT has applied principles such as "polluter pays" and precaution, reinforcing that faith cannot override ecological limits.

Is a per capita limit on offerings plausible and effective ?

Even minimal practices create a significant, continuous pollution load, say experts.

An analyses of offerings at Varanasi ghats with an average daily footfall of 2.5 lakh, shows minimal offerings of 5 ml milk, 5 ml oil(for lamps), and one flower per person, translating into 1,250 litres each of milk and oil, and 5 tonnes of flowers daily, excluding ashes, public offerings, and other waste. On peak days, this rises to 3,500 litres and 14 tonnes of waste.' It is argued that per capita limits alone are insufficient. Effective regulation must combine site-specific caps, waste collection, and diversion to ensure sustainable river management.

The debate is not about curbing faith, but about recognising ecological limits.

THE GIST

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